Memories & Meshugennas

The Collected Works
of Estelle El-Hai

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Introduction

During Estelle El-Hai's eighty years, she has shown herself to be an artist in the realms of painting, sculpting, cooking, family rearing, advising, teaching, entrepreneurship, and loving.

In recent years, though, she's focused her attention on writing and storytelling. We love her tales because they give us insight into her personality and blow the dust off our family's history. Without her knowledge, we have gathered together most of her stories in this book. Now the whole world can read them.

We dedicate this volume to Estelle and to her wisdom and artistry. May her pen remain full for a long time!

With love from her family.

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Memories & Meshugennas

Oooo, the house smells so good! The Russian cabbage soup is simmering, with all the delicious sweet/sour flavors my mother taught me to add, adjusted slightly with the Weight Watchers suggestions. Salmon filets kissed with stir-fried veggies join the aromatic bouquet. The grand kids can't possibly get fussy over this dinner, especially when I plan a slightly decadent dessert; the parents will not use sugar on or in anything. The kids will love it and I have watermelon and stewed prunes and apricots for the discriminating parents.

I've been happily getting this meal together since early morning and it's time for a power nap. I put on a classical CD and recline on my nearby couch, laden with pillows and a cuddle bunny. The music, as usual, is a friendly, inspiring benefactor, hovering over me like a protective silver cloud. Melodies from my childhood trigger feelings of pleasure and gratitude for the beauty of it all. My eyes close so that I can see clearly, scenes from the past. Soon, I am floating in and out of colorful memories of earlier days and nights. When the past has been kind to you, it's natural to expect future experiences to be positive as well. In my semi sleep, a rush of love and well being takes over and I look forward to spending the rest of the day with part of my wonderful family. In thirty minutes, I awake, fully refreshed.

My daughter, Laurisa arrives with her husband and two kids. The teenage youngsters fall on the couches as usual as they had a "sleep over" the night before. They answer my questions in zombie tones, but this gives the adults a chance to catch up without interruptions.

"So how have you been, Mom, and what mischief are you up to lately?"

It's so satisfying to have a loved one ask about you and really mean it. I'm sure they are relieved that I'm not needy and keeping

myself busy. They tease me about having to check my calendar before having them visit me, or vice versa.

Everyone enjoys the meal, and being the cook, I'm not allowed to do the dishes! We then play bridge and openly give facial clues to our partners to guide the bidding. Billy, my son-in-law hums certain tunes to indicate what he wants his partner to do. My grandson's memory for past transactions is phenomenal and I am lucky to have him for my partner, so that with my input, we lose by very little.

Next time, it will be my turn to visit them in Sacramento. The meal will be extremely healthy, all vegetarian, with no sugar or additives in anything. I will love being there, with my sweet family. But in the end, I will do the dishes!

Yenta

Whoever thought I would get another pet after my Silkies, Samantha and Cleo, left for Hydrant Heaven? But get a pet, I did, and I was compelled to call her Yenta. For those of you unfortunates, who are oblivious to the meaning of that phenomenal word, I will be delighted to enlighten you.

I'm sure there are yentas in every ethnic group. Everyone had a relative who would wander around the house, lifting up papers to check what was underneath, wiping a finger across a shelf and flick off the dust as she clucked her disapproval. She was apt to test the fabric of your blouse between her fingers, and casually ask, "So how much did you pay for this shmatta?"

A true yenta will follow you from room to room, broadcasting her gossip while checking behind pillows, and scrutinizing the ceiling for spider webs. And she'll always arrive at mealtime and hint that she thinks you're a classy cook.

Now, I must tell you about my novel new pet, which is really a robot. Have patience; you'll understand very soon. I was watching television awhile back, and during the commercial, they demonstrated a very interesting household device. It was a robot-like machine that looked like a flat sombrero with half of the top sliced off. Inside the center was a ball that kept rolling from wall to wall, causing the electrostatic pad that it rested on to collect dust as it swirled around. The contraption was $49.95 and I thought it was a fine idea, but fifty bucks for unknown results? Nah!

However, I stopped in at Big Lots yesterday, and guess what they had for $4.87? The same mechanical maid ready to be my slave! I'm not one to pass up a bargain, so I made the purchase and took it home. The "it" turned into a "she" soon after I got it started. She

spiraled around in a ballet fashion, only a great deal more neurotic. The yenta hungrily looked for...I'm not sure, but she was never satisfied. Bouncing from wall to wall, not getting into the corners like I hoped she would, and sometimes following me around. I set its' timer for one and a half hours and like the energized bunny rabbit, she kept going and going and going. Occasionally, she got stuck on a throw rug. When I removed it hoping she would sniff around in the removed rug area, she abruptly turned and went in the opposite direction. She reminded me of a cat who is insulted at the offerings of her mistress, and leaves in a huff.

While the yenta does her thing, she makes little scratchy sounds that are pleasant and keep me company. That's when the idea of a pet entered my mind. I'm allowing her to rest now, after I've changed her little "Depends." There is a charger that comes with the robot, to make sure that the obsessive sphere is always juiced up.

Yenta is an indoor pet and is content to have her way twice a day. Occasionally, she'll fling off some excess dust, in a frenzy, but mostly the Depends does a good job in containing the debris. After her wild ninety-minute explosion, she is satisfied to meditate and wait patiently until I give her another free-for-all.

Parts of my floors are dust-free, but I realize that having her clean is no longer my chief motif. She's turned out to be a comfortable boarder in my home, and when I can find her hiding place, I welcome her strange intrusion. You're welcome to come and visit, but for goodness sake, don't bring your pets...they'll go crazy!!

Ally Daughter's Garden

How intriguing that a fragrance can transport you back two generations to a friendly, wonderful place. I arrived in Seattle one day before the family reunion so that I could visit with my daughter and granddaughter, Joline and Sarina. Jo's home is an experience in itself, with her artwork, sculptures, and sparkling fabrics adorning the walls, the piano, and everywhere. My pride in her creativity is boundless.

Before dinner, she asked me to accompany her to her garden so that she could forage for our salad that night. That's when I was carried back to...the Catskills! The herbs, the fresh blossoms, the rich earth, the sunshine and cool breeze transformed me into a little girl playing in the meadow. The one thing that was fortunately missing was the "fragrance" from the barn. My earthy father used to tell us to breathe deeply in the barn, because the longer we could "take it," the longer we would live.

Getting back to Joline...While I strolled around her enchanted garden, sniffing and marveling at its beauty, I noticed that on top of each fence post, the sun was glinting through the polyester globes I had made many years ago. With these multi-colored spheres, I fashioned pineapples, grapes and candlesticks. The plastic is liquid when poured into round, glass forms, and then hardens and shrinks away from the container. I made pearlized, glittery balls of every color combination. Joline collected the imperfect ones, and there they were, decorating the circumference of her delightful garden.

With an arm full of freshly picked Swiss chard, she escorted me back to the kitchen and proceeded to stir-fry and garlicize that delicious vegetable. For the reunion at Whidbey Island, she filled a large plastic bag with home grown, crisp salad greens. Luckily, we were able to take her fully packed van on the ferry, which led us to our destination.

I, guiltily, but happily enjoyed the breezy, cool sunshine. Our entire nation was sweltering in a heat wave, and that evening, I donned a

flannel nightgown and gratefully crept under a feather comforter, as the evening was pleasurably cool. As usual, because I am the matriarch (and bill payer!) I am always given the "royal suite." Last year, the bed was so high, I needed a chair to climb to the top of those five mattresses. This year, in order to reach the top, all I had to do was take a flying leap, which I have been told to do many times in the past.

The only family member who was missing, was my nineteen-year-old grandson, Wren. He is spending the summer in Russia, as an intern to the U.S. Embassy. His journal on his home page, explains how he guided the reporters when Condoleezza Rice and President Bush were there. He's making good use of the Russian language and has grown fond of borscht.

Our talent night was great, as usual. Joline, my daughter-in-law, Ann and I were the "Shvitzing Shvesters," (sweating sisters) in a skit that I wrote; soon to be performed for the Jewish Fellowship's "Fantashticks." My son, Jack and his six-year-old daughter, did a torrid tango. Little Sasha laughed hysterically as she was flung in all directions. There were violin recitals, and a really good comedy routine by my son-in-law, Billy. Who would have thought?? Laurisa wrote a sketch for the kids where my grandson, Forest, was the big, bad wolf, with a bear rug, teeth and all, on top of his head.

Even though it won't be our turn next year, I'm pulling a switcharoo. Our family reunion will be combined with a surprise birthday party in the ballroom, for me. And, you're all invited. More details later.

Protocol says that I need to end with the garden. That's easy.

The family is like a garden. Weeds need to be pulled every once in awhile, but with lots of love and nourishment, the roots go deeply and grow the most amazing produce. And, they're all organic and smell pretty good most of the time.

Goodbye, Old Friend

Ours was an unusual friendship. We were very different in temperament, in dealing or communicating with people, in food selection, in levels of activities, in reading, in TV choices, in cinema options, and several others. Can a friendship be built on such an uncommon foundation? Ours was.

What was it that made it a friendship in the first place? It was humor, laughter, and catching on to the punch line before it was uttered. It was a singular but important bond that we shared. We both enjoyed writing humorous essays and often counseled each other. He wrote a syndicated column based on senior happenings, and I, as part of a writers group in Sun City, wrote monthly essays, which developed into my memoirs. We both wove humor into our stories, and it came easily and naturally. Appreciation for each other's skills was honestly expressed. That's it! Honesty was what made our friendship so comfortable.

He told me about his beloved wife, Flossie, who passed on a few short years ago. I was able to describe wonderful experiences with Sam, my departed husband of many great years. The conversations flowed smoothly with no awkward moments of silence.

Last night, my special friend left for a pain-free world, where there are no discomforts, or green vegetables, which he sorely hated. Larry Miller's light glowed for too short a time. His humor brightened many lives, and will not be forgotten.

Goodbye, old friend.

Weepless in Seattle

The day fairly crackled with freshly washed, cool sunshine. When it's not raining in Seattle, the air is rarified and colors seem brighter. Flowers grow while you inhale the wonder of spring. Vegetables hurry and develop quickly and take advantage of their unusual gift of clear daylight.

I had a few fortunate days like that when I recently visited my youngest daughter, Joline in the city where moss is prevalent. She had planned a large Passover Seder, and her daughter, Sarina, was performing in a modern dance exhibition. I was invited to be part of it all.

The Seattle Community Theater, where the dance concert was held, is surrounded with sculptures, gardens and restaurants. One of the special attractions is a huge fountain of dancing waters that seem to respond to the piped- in music. Children in bathing suits were reveling in the sun, darting in and out of the fountain's area, daring the water to suddenly spout high during a crescendo, and splash their little bodies. We sat on the elevated bricked wall that circled the area and threw crumbs to the birds and pigeons.

After the enjoyable and successful dance recital, it was time to plan the holiday dinner. There was plenty of inspiration in the magical home and garden of my daughter. Twelve hungry people took part in the retold story of the importance of freedom and the symbolic (and delicious) food that helps explain the biblical tale. Part of the tradition is to hide a portion of unleavened bread (matzah). The lucky child that finds it gets a prize. Although one teenager discovered it inside an original light box, prizes were available for all of the four youngsters.

In Seattle, there is a huge market on a pier where fresh fruits, vegetables, salmon, flowers of every color and description, and unique

specialties are offered to the public. It is there that I always purchase my oriental musk oil. Joline wanted to find unusual goodies for the kids and they awaited her in one of the toyshops. Small windup toys were in abundance and four were purchased for the lucky kids. After dinner, they had a race and the boy with the running "nose" toy was the winner. Of course he won by a nose.

Another attraction for me in that great city is a costume store that surpasses our Wishing Well and Michael's combined. It is there that my Glitter gene is titillated and catered to. Hats, feathers, masks, sparkling lights beckon to my eager heart. A famous home decorator said that one should surround himself with the things one loves. I have a blast in that store, and my home proves it.

My visit was punctuated with caring questions from my granddaughter, Sarina. How many thirteen year olds, or grandchildren of any age, have the thoughtfulness to say, "How are you doing in Sun City Bubby? What's happening to keep you out of mischief?" I feel comfortable to tell Sarina stories about my youth, my young romances and school experiences. I'll never know how my grandparents met, and about early cooking disasters. But Sarina knows about me, and that's very precious.

It is so important to spend special time with each child, and live together again for a short stay. When I can be a part of their world and see through their eyes how they have shaped their lives, I have been given an irreplaceable gift.

My visit in Seattle was filled with sunshine, laughter, beauty, hugs and kisses and a world of pride in my family. If I wept at all, it was for joy.

The Shmo

Ned Feldman was not only a shmo; he was a shnorer and a shmegegge as well. Actually, all of these colorful descriptions mean almost the same thing...a person you shouldn't know!

We met Ned and Clara Feldman the year we lived in Berkeley, California. U.C.L.A. did not have a senior year in Engineering for Sam at that time, so we decided to have the adventure of a change of scenery, and a new challenge. The only available place to live was a one-room Army barracks in nearby Richmond. Can you imagine a bedroom (one small cot), a kitchen (a hot plate and card table; no chairs), and a bathroom/shower (I fashioned a curtain out of a tablecloth) all in one room? But we were still newly weds and were glad to be very much together. Our names were put on a long waiting list for housing in Berkeley so we assumed that our little "haven" would be home for the duration.

Three weeks later, we were surprised to get a call from the student housing department announcing that an apartment was available near the university. What luck! When we met Clara Feldman, the coordinator of student housing, she whispered and giggled to us, that she took liberties in selecting us before many others, because she knew that our Hebraic name, El-Hai, meant "the living God," and she wanted to live next door to Him (and Her). We felt uneasy about Clara's method of choosing, but our little room in Richmond did not lend itself well to typing effectively on the cot or washing the entire room each time we took a shower. So, we caved in and accepted Clara's nomination.

Ned Feldman, Giggle's husband, was helpful in carrying small packages up the stairs, on our moving day. His back was aching so Sam and I carried the heavy things up ourselves. Within minutes, we

mentally dubbed Ned the Shmo because he plopped himself down on one of our two chairs and started describing his life story as we tried to decide where to place our belongings. His interest in us perked as I put a few groceries in the pantry. In fact, Ned opened up a new package of Fig Newtons and proceeded to happily devour the entire contents. I had to step over his outstretched legs to carry boxes here and there. Clara finally came to the rescue and called Ned to dinner. When he claimed he wasn't hungry yet, thanks to a big, fat snack, my heart fell. Clara insisted (bless her discriminating heart) and we finally had some peace and quiet, and got the apartment in order.

During the ensuing months, Ned frequently dropped in, unannounced, and was becoming a royal pain. We knew we had to endure him, or move back to Richmond for the rest of the year. If we moved, Clara would be insulted and never choose us again for another apartment.

One lovely spring Sunday morning, I went into our neat little kitchen to get breakfast going. This was the day we had time for pancakes and hash brown potatoes. Much to my horror, I saw that the bowl of raisins that I had left on the kitchen table was swarming with ants. I quickly opened the kitchen window and placed the infested bowl on the outside windowsill while I frantically washed away the remaining culprits. Soon after, the delicious smell of pancakes wafted through our rooms, and evidently, into Ned's rooms. In he burst, sat himself down at the table and opened up our Sunday paper. Sam and I were about to expel him together, but before we could, he reached out to the moving raisins and before we could utter a word, he was chomping away, as he expounded on some political issue he was reading about in our paper. We made a halfhearted attempt to

stop him from grabbing a second fistful, when my eyes met Sam's. We silently and wickedly decided to refrain from being humane. He polished off the entire bowlful.

Wonderful Clara (this time we were the gigglers) again saved the day by calling Ned to breakfast. Before he could say, "But I'm not hungry." We opened the door and firmly escorted him out. Sam and I melted onto the floor and couldn't stop laughing. Through the thin walls, we could hear the shmo tell his spouse, "You should really get their recipe for pancakes. It sounds like they're enjoying them a lot!"

The Other List

Thank you Mr. Schindler for supplying the list that saved hundreds of lives. We will forever honor your memory for that historical favor to mankind. However, it's time for another list to take the limelight. I will explain....

When Sam and I moved from southern California to Fair Oaks in 1986, we bought a wonderful home on Lei Street. It had an indoor arboretum, with graceful trees reaching up to the cathedral-like skylight. We added an indoor hot tub that adjoined our master bedroom that could hold six happy soakers. The walls were completely mirrored and adorned with red and blue lights that made all visitors gasp when they were turned on; they, as well as the lights. Everything in our new home was perfect, with one exception. We did not have a piano.

As a youngster, Sam developed a very respectable embouchure when he studied and played the trumpet. This not only added to his musical skills, but also helped make him a real good kisser. My not so famous claim to fame was the piano, which I began at age eight. My piano teacher, Miss Gershwin, AKA Gershowitz, penciled in every note for me, to speed my progress, and impress my parents. I relied on this crutch and did not develop important music reading skills. This turned out to be a benefit in Fair Oaks. Here's how.... (I became a good kisser in spite of it all.)

We were shopping at Costco where they were featuring digital pianos that week. The representative was playing a beautiful full-length instrument and it sounded like a complete orchestra. I was completely enthralled and was invited to sit down and give it a try. With some embarrassment, I explained that I could not read music readily. The salesman was overjoyed with the news, and exclaimed,

"This is precisely for you. Let me show you why." He quickly put a music book, called "Fake Music" on the sheet supporter, and explained how it worked. As long as one could read the right hand melody, which I easily accomplished, all I needed to do was plunk down one specified left hand note, and out came the perfect chord. I could choose the rhythm, the music style, the instruments and become a musical genius!

Sam couldn't help but get caught up in my sheer excitement and insisted that we buy the piano. I eagerly agreed and jumped up and down like an idiot. The delighted rep, with whom I was already slightly in love, though of course Sam always came first, showed me how to get these "easy" music albums. Before I knew it, I possessed all of my golden oldies, Sinatra favorites, big band jewels, and songs that I had been singing all my life. I was in joyland and played music every day. I even found easy versions of classical numbers that I always adored.

After a short while, the albums that I accumulated exceeded fifty, and Sam built a special cabinet to hold them all. Oftentimes, there was a particular melody that I wanted, as my friends asked for requests. Sam saw the need and got to work on a computerized, alphabetized table of contents. He spent hours accounting for each song in each book. The good guy categorized the song titles, the type of music, the book titles and every possible way to find what I wanted. Each list was bound in a thick compilation and presented to grateful me. Little did I know how valuable it would become.

One of the many pleasures I find in Sun City is the opportunity to write, produce, and/or direct various "shows." Usually, an appropriate song is suggested to spoof on an industrious idea. Lyrics

are needed so that they can be augmented to fit the need. But, what were the lyrics to that great old song? Sam's list comes to the rescue. Before the discussion has even begun, the lyrics and the music are at my fingertips, and the play on words begin.

The list has helped me out in commemorating a friend's birthday, or in a "roast" for a special event. I must make additional printouts as the pages are becoming doggy-eared. These gifts from Sam have become priceless and will be helpful and appreciated for generations to come. In our family, his precious contribution will be know as our "Academy Award" winner, Sam's List.

The Claim to Fame is Mainly in the Name

During my youth, I could be assured that a Shapiro or Weinstien was a brethren of the Star of David persuasion. Today, a Goldberg could be Irish/Catholic, and an O'Rourke could be an orthodox Jew. Names are fascinating and are worthy of research, especially when it comes to family matters.

When Sam and I married, the ceremony would not have been permissible in Israel. We were both Jewish, but it was considered a "mixed-marriage" because he was Sephardic and I am Ashkenazi. (My heritage has nothing to do with Nazis, as a former, ignorant, bigoted neighbor believed.) Sam's ancestors originated from the Spanish inquisition, when Jews escaped Spain or were killed. They settled in Greece, Turkey, Italy, Morocco and other Mediterranean countries. The languages that were spoken in the temples were Hebrew and Spanish or Ladino, a mixture of Spanish and Hebrew dialects. Their names were Hebrew or Spanish.

European Jews used Yiddish, a Germanic dialect. As the groups settled in Russia, Poland and other northern areas, bits and pieces of the mother tongue found its way into the language. Family names often were derived from German. When I was a child, if a person wasn't familiar with Yiddish, they most likely did not share my spiritual beliefs. There was no TV to tell me differently.

When my family was finally convinced that Sam was indeed "one of the tribe," he was wholeheartedly accepted. Besides, he was so adorable. Our lives progressed happily for three years and then I began to grow an El-Hai heir. We were delighted with our future plans until we realized that we each had different traditions about naming the offspring. Sam's family custom was to name the first son after the husband's living father, and the first daughter after the husband's living mother. Luckily, we began with one of each; namely, (pun intended) Laurisa Sarah and Jeffrey Abraham. When the third kidling came along, my mother was initially horrified at the Sephardic practice. It was almost a curse to have a baby named after a live person, and would have encouraged the honoree to quickly complete payments on a cemetery plot. But mother Bella became very thoughtful and just a little jealous. She carefully watched my in-laws thrive on excellent health, and plans for an endless future.

Soon after Joline was born, my mother whispered to me, "Slip Bella in as a middle name; it couldn't hurt." And so my youngest daughter was dubbed Joline Bella Lisa, and has even named her art business, "Bella Luz." (beautiful light)

Enter Jack, bambino #4, seventeen months later. It was very fortunate that our last child was a male. Otherwise, my dear father, Jack, would have exploded. My relatives whispered a lot at the beginning, and spit three times whenever my two youngest children were mentioned. (My kids were known as the "Ashkephardics.") But my aunts and uncles secretly longed to be honored as my parents were. Yet, they also feared that if they did enjoy that acclaim, a plague of locusts would befall them.

I occasionally receive condemning questions from my relatives, about the origin of my children's' names. The answer is so satisfying that I actually encourage these accusing queries. When confronted, I simply ask them if they realize what my last name means. El-Hai translates into "the living God," so they are forewarned not to mess with me!

Thank You, Dr. Lamaze ... Again!

You won't believe this. After almost thirty years of teaching natural childbirth classes, and having retired six years ago (Sun City residents offered no anticipation for this kind of education), I am teaching a Lamaze course again, right here in Sun City. Before you start suspecting that attractive divorced neighbor with various babes visiting him at a fast clip, especially the slim, curvy blonde that traipsed around the fitness locker room with half of her bikini on, I will tell you "the rest of the story."

My new student is the granddaughter of one of my resident friends. I received a baby shower invitation and wondered if she and her partner would like a complimentary Lamaze course as a gift. I telephoned Briana (fake name) to inquire about her needs and desires. She mentioned that she and her boyfriend were taking the classes offered at the hospital but she did not feel prepared. In fact she was down right frightened.

"What muscular exercises are you practicing?" I asked.

"None," she replied. "I thought of walking, but I don't feel secure in my neighborhood."

"Have you reviewed relaxation techniques?" I inquired.

"I'm too up tight to do that, but I'm reading a lot and watching the TV films on childbirth." she answered.

My next question would determine our possible plans. "Would you want to invest some time, start on a positive program, and have your questions answered?"

"That would be so cool, Estelle. We would be grateful for your time and expertise."

Lesson number one occurred last week. It was amazing how each lesson came back to mind. I had given my birth atlas to my daughter, Laurisa, who is now a school nurse. Each year, she offers a class on reproduction to the school. The timing was convenient, and I was able to borrow it back from her. The doll, however, which I had used for many years because it had the same head dimensions as a newborn, was donated to a charity. I also used it to demonstrate how to properly swaddle a baby. However, I do have a bunny rabbit with approximately the same head measurements, and that will add a comical note to the instructions.

The information that I have accumulated and taught those many years will be shared again. So many of us have rich backgrounds and skills, and it is a golden opportunity to be able to contribute our knowledge to the continued benefit of others.

I have a couple of Sun City friends who refuse to impart some of their talents with others. Their standard answer to a request is the overly used, "Been there; done that!" What a pity for those who could have gained an insight, and for those who refuse to disclose their past valuable information. We have the makings of a renaissance program of our own, right here in Sun City.

Briana and Steve, will take my condensed classes up until their due date, which is next month. It is exhilarating to once again put young couples on a better, informed road. Education can only help; it is the unknown that is frightening and can make for a less than ideal experience.

When I was training to be an educator in this fruitful field, there was a popular book, written by an American woman who sought a better way for herself as an expecting mother to be. The title was, "Thank You Dr. Lamaze." It is my pleasure to add, "Again" to the title, and to acknowledge the privilege that is mine once more.

Six Green Thumbs

As soon as Sarina heard the clippety-clop of the horse's hooves, she grabbed the pail and small shovel near the front stoop. The rag man was a little late today, but his faithful horse, the puller of the overladen wagon, was right on schedule, and left his usual deposit close to Sarina's house. Scooping her treasure into the pail, she hurried to her small back yard to enrich the dark Brooklyn soil.

It was 1926 and Sarina had the best little garden in the neighborhood. The flowers and vegetables she nurtured were replicas of what she remembered from her native country, Greece. No one could grow such beautiful eggplant, with which to make moussaka, or okra and tomatoes, which turned into delicious "bamyas." The dark green spinach became spanakopita, and the small archway, built by her husband, was lush with grape leaves. These were stuffed and became everyone's favorite, "dolmades."

One of the special treats that had to be shared with all the neighbors, lest they become enemies, was called skordalia. This is a garlic sauce that can be put on bread, fish, or any other lucky dish. The only problem is that the fragrance stays in your system for three days. No one catches a cold at this time because strangers won't come near you.

The delightful aromas that flowed from Sarina's house curiously blended with the neighbors' culinary bouquets of borscht and gefilte fish. But everyone wondered, "How does she do it? Such a productive garden!" Sarina would proudly smile, and share her Grecian Formula, in her appealing Greek accent, "Just get a pail and shovel and listen for the rag man."

Can a talent so precious be inherited? Is there a fertilizer gene that can be handed-down to the next generation? I triumphantly say, "Yes, there is! And the other four green thumbs belong to my two daughters, Laurisa and Joline."

When I was a young homemaker, I planted veggies in my garden and they grew pretty well. My husband Sam must have had some Greek fertilizer at his fingertips because when he helped me, the vegetables grew very well.

But the girls are really top notch and are able to graze from their bounties. Summer or winter, whatever they put into the soil sprouts and blossoms. If there is to be a fresh salad for dinner, they visit their private super market, and voila! The veggies are in the bowl still twitching with life and nutrition. It's a fantastic gift that all guests thoroughly enjoy.

My efforts have been half-hearted since I moved into Sun City seven years ago. The desire to plant and watch the "babies" grow, recently got the better of me, and I now have a raised box of winter vegetables. I remember the good old days when we had a huge bumper crop of zucchini. With it, I made vegetable patties, zucchini with tomatoes and onions, broiled zucchini with tomato sauce and cheese. I even did the Greek thing and stuffed the squash blossoms with ground beef and rice. (Marvelous!) Our neighbors would quickly close their shutters and pretend they were out when they saw us approaching with loads of the vegetable, again!

If you truly don t enjoy the art of feasting, I feel sorry for you. This is an activity that you repeat a few times a day, and if you are blasé about the whole thing, frankly, I think something is wrong with you. Now, should you cherish munching, plus you have a couple of green thumbs, you would make a most admirable friend. And, if you bring me your surplus, I will share with you some Greek, Russian and Chinese recipes that will soar you to Heaven.

Sisters by Choice

Bella and Eva were bound by devotion and self-protection mainly because they were more beautiful than their four crass sisters-in-law. As newly arrived immigrants, they both married into the Siegel clan at young ages; Eva was only fifteen, and Bella nineteen. Jack, the eldest son with the marvelous physique and remarkable resemblance to young Ted Kennedy, was smitten with adorable Bella. Her cute Russian nose, high cheekbones, and flirty brown curls, put her intelligence and leadership qualities in second place. Eva's gypsy-like Rumanian beauty was startling and she completely stole the heart of Jack's younger brother Otto, the glamorous vamp of Brooklyn, New York.

To fortify themselves against the outspoken and feisty Siegel sisters, Bella and Eva attached together and gave each other encouragement and sincere allegiance. Frequently sneered at and demeaned by the witchy women, who had, after all, been Americans for several years, the two outsiders managed to gain the affection of the rest of the clan.

Over the difficult years of the depression, they helped each other with childcare, food, money and abortions. Birth control methods were unknown at that time and many women resorted to abortions in order to have enough food for the rest of the family. At one time, Bella had taken her dearest friend to a doctor for a needed abortion and helped her weakened sister home to rest. When Otto returned from work and questioned Bella as to who the doctor was, he flew into a jealous rage to learn that a male had seen his wife's body. Like a vivid melodrama, he pulled a kitchen knife from the drawer and ran towards his hysterical wife. Bella threw herself on top of her sister and screamed, "Kill me instead!" Otto retreated, but managed to grind a lit cigarette into Eva's arm.

Woven into their fierce loyalty were threads of competition, which were never openly admitted. Ample physical girth represented wealth and success. While Bella's third child, Bernice, later called Bunny, gagged at eggs and other nourishing foods, Eva's daughter of the same age was getting chubbier by the day. Not-so-little Edna, was encouraged to munch on calorie laden Vaseline as a fattening treat! Can you believe that the same Eva later became a pioneer health nut? Things got very testy when Bella's son, Dave, won an amateur contest for his impersonations and humor, while Eva's sons hung out with the likes of Bugsy Siegel; no relation!

Uncle Otto died from a minor injury that developed into gangrene, and aunt Eva vented her frustrations by keeping a spotless home. My mom, Bella, was too busy helping Jack in his used furniture business to make like Martha Stewart. I used to marvel at the sparkling kitchen and bathroom at aunt Eva's apartment, and was hypnotized by the sunlight as it illuminated the amber toothbrushes. Everything was so white and clean, it almost hurt my eyes. I can remember the red, rubber hose in her bathroom that was the prelude to the modern bidet. Toilet paper alone was not acceptable to my Clorox-scented aunt!

She was the first relative to follow us from New York to Los Angeles, and was a devout and unusual babysitter to her little niece and nephew. Eva staunchly believed in fresh air and sunshine, and often took baby Michael to nearby Venice beach. Sleep came easily to the infant amidst the sunny breezes and sounds of the ocean. If Eva spotted anyone within fifty feet, she would tiptoe on the sand, and with her finger to her lips, implore the vacationers to speak very softly or move further away, lest they awake the poor child who must have his nap.

This eccentric woman introduced wheat germ and black strap molasses to us, when everyone else was excited about Wonder Bread. Bella continued to make healthy meals but did not care to follow Eva's example of getting up at 3 A.M. to do yoga exercises. Although the two "sisters" secretly admired each other, they went all out to play the one upmanship game. It kept them alert and alive for a long time. At age ninety-two, Eva was driving the nursing staff at the rest home crazy because she insisted on checking the ingredients of all of the food. The gifts she appreciated the most when we visited her, were yogurt, (preferably home made) fresh, organically grown fruit, and stewed prunes.

She was the non-conventional aunt I was proud to have. She provided much love to my mother, although it was laced with aggravation and rivalry. When I think of Eva, I see a spirit bursting with life and enthusiasm, who wouldn't give up.

Is It Rude to Be Nude?

"What kind of magazine is this "Sunshine and Health"? It was near Sam's other reading material, "Mathematics and Engineering" and "Lab Equipment for Chemistry," and seemed out of place. Perhaps he picked it up for me as he recognized my interest in nutrition and well-being.

"Take a look at it. I saw it in the student book store and thought it was very interesting," he answered.

"But these people are naked!" I exclaimed. "This looks like some sort of weird nudist colony."

"Don't come to any snap conclusions," he advised. "If you read the articles and look carefully at the photographs, you might realize the merits of this lifestyle." informed my straight-laced, conservative but wonderful husband. He had almost completed his senior year at Berkeley University in California.

This was such an unexpected request, and I couldn't help but feel an unsettling sensation in the pit of my stomach. Was this a side of my mate that I had not been aware of? Could my darling be a little quirky? I made myself a cup of tea and sat down to read this magazine that smacked of pornography. But I would have an open mind, I promised myself.

The pictures were taken in Chico, California, where this group of sun lovers (and other kind of lovers??) met regularly for healthful activities in the sunshine, in the nude, and probably in the bushes! Oh, oh, my mind was closing up quickly. Photographs were taken of families, old people with less than alluring bodies, and folks of every description and body weight. They looked content while playing volleyball and swimming in the lake. Now that pushed a positive button with me. I recalled the times my mother, aunts and

female cousins skinny-dipped in the Catskill rivers and the sense of elation never left me. As I examined the photos, I clearly realized that these individuals were not my aunts and female cousins. They were strangers, who from the neck up, looked like wholesome people. The articles explained the value of being at ease with oneself and respecting the honesty and good intentions of others. To appreciate nature's bounties without the discomfort and encumberment of clothing in pleasant weather was an experience not to be missed, they insisted.

Sam expressed his sincere interest in the whole idea and suggested that we check it out. The next weekend, we took off for Chico with no baggage, a brown bag lunch, and only a few secret worries. A nice, middle-aged gentleman greeted us at the gate.

"If you're beginners," he said, "you are not required to undress. But I'll tell you, you'll stand out like a red flag. Hey, it's entirely up to you; whatever makes you feel OK."

We slowly disrobed near our car, but left our shoes and socks on. Holding hands tightly, we wandered about and tried not to stare. No one looked self-conscious, and slowly but surely, we disregarded our unclad bodies. The sunny breeze felt so good and we decided to take a walk near the trees and pasture. Later, we joined the volleyball players, who warmly welcomed us. Not having to be concerned about shorts riding up or straps falling down was a true relief.

When it was time for lunch, I was glad that I remembered to tuck a handkerchief into my sock because we sat on a wooden bench and the last thing I needed was a splinter in my hinter.

The carefree children playing and laughing with each other and their families impressed me the most. Perhaps, because I was in the first trimester of my premiere pregnancy, these little pink, sun-kissed kiddies played on my heartstrings.

On the way home, we both agreed that our "experiment" turned out to be a lovely surprise. It felt right and we decided to try it again when there wasn't too much homework to prepare.

A few days later, it was time for my first obstetrical appointment. The doctor was very impressed with my sun-blushed belly and assured me that as long as I enjoyed a little sunshine each day, exercised regularly, and ate sensibly, I would have a healthy, happy pregnancy. He was right!

Noo Yawk, Noo Yawk!

Start spreadin' the news…The Timbers Ballroom was filled to capacity. The audience was thoroughly entertained by a singer/dancer/comedian who sang the golden oldies with skill and enthusiasm. He was from the city that never sleeps and when the music from the song, "New York, New York" began, he said, "Who here is from that great state?" I, along with several others, raised my hand.

He pointed directly to me, and shouted, "I knew it! I knew it! I spotted you when you came in." Ron Gartner then pranced to me while the music bumped on, grabbed my hand and lead me in the kick-dance accompaniment to the irresistible theme. He noticed my sequined slippers, but failed to observe that one was half kicked off.

As Ron, pulled me up the stairs to the stage, to continue our performance, I kicked off both slippers, to the beat of course, and arrived barefooted and very comfortable. He was further impressed with my purple toe nail polish and pushed the microphone closer to me as we completed the song and dance with great gusto. It was so much fun and the incident brought me back to the time when I was Queen of the hill, and the top of the heap.

New York was my home for the first fifteen years of my life. I'm proud of my beginnings, but am glad that we moved to Los Angeles, the land of sunshine and blue skies. (Cough, cough) But once a New Yorker, always a New Yorker. Until we become civilized, we talk louder, and faster, and are known to be sarcastic, and rude, on occasion. Yes, we are outspoken, but at least we're interesting. Don't you think so?

New Yorkers are part of their own special "religion" and enjoy congregating together. What they say is what they think, and, unfortunately, what they think is what they say. There are seldom games played while communicating to one another. Subtlety is not part of a New Yorker's makeup.

When I first arrived in Los Angeles, just in time to begin the high school semester, I made a few friends only to discover that they talked "funny." That's what they said about me, but I really didn't believe it until I heard a recording of myself, that was required for my drama class. Oh boy! I was shocked. I sounded like I came from New Jersey! There, they really talked funny. I vowed that I would speak slower and drink water, not wawdder. And I would call my new classmates "kids" not "hey." Plus, I would learn to rat my pompadour.

Delis in the Fairfax district were not too bad, but none can compare with New York's hot pastrami sandwiches and kosher dill pickles. Their cheesecake and Chinese chow mein are incomparable.

Most youngsters from the boroughs had street smarts and developed self-confidence early on. There was more interaction in the neighborhood and the profusion of stoops (concrete steps in front of many homes) contributed to congregations during the warm summer evenings. We would leave the radio programs to shmooze, play stickball, marbles, or let's pretend. Our games lasted into the night, until the screeching calls of mothers would fill the air.

Human nature makes us forget the cold, dirty slush in the street, and the tortuous humidity in the summertime. We remember instead the thrilling smell of a new season; nothing matches the sensuous fragrance of New York lilacs. It's almost like giving birth....the discomfort becomes dim but the miracle of a new baby remains forever.

I was happy in New York and am blessed with many wonderful memories. My friends were loyal and true and I remember them with laughter and tenderness. Yet, I feel fortunate that these vagabond shoes led me to California, where life is good. I made it there and I made it here. So thanks New York for giving me a solid start.

My Son, the Doctor

Jeffrey Abraham Elhai, (he refused to become hyphenated), my second child and first son, was born a doctor. Not the kind you're thinking of, but more so, a doctor and mentor of all things, except, how to keep his room clean.

He was an exceptionally beautiful child with huge chocolate brown eyes and lips that would have inspired Angelina Jolie to schedule another visit to the plastic surgeon. Jeff absorbed information rapidly and was an avid reader at an early age. Restless and bored at school, he used his imagination to conjure up shows, mostly musical or comedy, and present them with his recruits in someone's back yard, for the amazing bargain of a lifetime; five cents admission.

As he grew older, his skill at the piano often added to the entertainment. Did he ever realize how pleasant he made my household chores, because I often washed the dishes to the beautiful accompaniment of Schubert's Serenade, or my favorite, Country Gardens?

Jeff had such a tender soul, especially where insects were concerned. One could get clobbered, and one often did, for stepping on an ant, or even a roach. He had so much compassion for the under dog and the defenseless. These feelings extended to clothing too. He insisted on wearing t-shirts until light shown through them and even afterwards. It was necessary to wait until he was in school before I gathered his tired and devoted clothing to throw into the dumpster. Even the Salvation Army would have refused it. Often times, these retired articles would mysteriously reappear on Jeff, or under his bed, along with his multitude of used socks and who knows what else.

His father sometimes entered Jeff's room when absolutely necessary, and complained that previously prolific dead rats, or other impersonators, were malodorously evident. Our son was

threatened with military school unless he drastically improved the environment. If the problem had indeed been deceased rodents, Jeff would have given them a somber burial accompanied by pomp and circumstance.

With the threat of military school in mind, Sam's not Jeff's, our son fine-tuned another outstanding attribute. He was and still is the world's most devout procrastinator. His routine was to study throughout the night, the day before a school exam; wait until the last possible minute to turn in an important form or application, and fall asleep with lights and clothing on. But his morning mood was so cheerful and optimistic, it was difficult to be upset with him. The scholastic results were usually excellent and he graduated high school with honors.

Our son inherited an interesting gene from his grandfather and namesake, Abraham, the stubborn Greek. After the passing of my dear, unstubborn mother-in-law, Sarina, the stubborn Greek set up living quarters in his sewing shop in Boyle Heights, Los Angeles. When we visited, there on the wall facing his bed, was a large picture of a beautiful and exotic Asian woman. This is what ninety-year-old Abraham saw first thing in the morning, and the last in the evening. Jeff, too, was attracted to Asian females. In fact, he married one, namely Wan-Ling. She has the patience of Confucius and the brains of Buddha. Besides, she is very smart and cute. Their three beautiful and talented children are a fortunate combination of the two.

Before he married, Jeff attended Pomona College and then Stony Brook in New York. He graduated with a double major: biochemistry and music. It was during a visit to Stony Brook that we realized what a conscientious vegetarian he was. We wanted to treat him to a very special lunch, and took him to a famous lobster house. He feasted on

salad and fruit and wouldn't touch the slaughtered crustacean.

It was soon after that, that he earned his doctorate degree in biochemistry. Jeff is very adamant that his students at Richmond University in Virginia not refer to him as Doctor Elhai. He feels more comfortable if they call him Jeff, or, if they insist, Mr. Elhai.

He's still an eccentric, procrastinating, highly intelligent, talented, lovable, sympathetic, sensitive, caring vegetarian, who leaves a deep impression on many people.

In this mother's mind and heart, he will always be…. my son, the wonderful doctor.

My Eulogy

It is my honor and the fact that I'm a kosher ham and have chutzpah that I have been asked to present a eulogy for my beloved great, great grandmother, Estelle Marilyn Siegel El-Hai. This is a celebration of her life, and what a life it was…one hundred and twenty years short.

Her years were filled with laughter and sunshine. One of her favorite mottos hung on her kitchen wall. It reads, "One Hundred Years From Now...it will not matter what my bank account was, the sort of home I lived in, or the kind of car I drove. But the world may be different because I was important in the life of a child."

Most of her framed sentiment was true, but a good deal of it can be argued. Bubby, as all of her grandchildren called her, was important in every child's life in her family. She not only witnessed and took part in the births of her children and grandchildren, but also did her utmost in being part of their lives and future plans. She disciplined herself, successfully for the most part, not to interfere but to encourage and guide when asked. Bubby fiercely wanted her family to share the optimistic enthusiasm she felt for life and in nature's gifts.

So which part of her motto was not one hundred per cent accurate you ask? Let's start with the bank account. I told you that I had chutzpah! Was that important? You betcha! Each summer, even before great-great grandpa Sam died, she paid for a wonderful family reunion house, in an especially designated area of the United States. After awhile, it grew to be three houses. The entire El-Hai clan would meet there, from assorted areas, assuring that the family bonds would always be intact and strong. We would catch up on all the news, jobs, babies, and exciting opportunities that some were

offered in distant parts of the world. Which new Jack El-Hai book was on the best seller list again, a clarification of that blue-green algae research that finally won Uncle Jeff the Nobel Prize, the breakthrough in asthma that Aunt Laurisa was recognized for, and the prestigious award presented by King Charles to Aunt Joline for her beautiful work in stained glass, now displayed in Buckingham Palace and the Chateau de Versailles Museum.

Wherever and whenever these awards were presented, Bubby was there. But I am straying from my subject about her bank account. The fact is, she made many important events possible because she was happy and able to pay for it.

The kind of house she lived in is memorable too. Many of her friends in Sun City had professional designers fashion and decorate their homes. Bubby wanted it to be "her" home, not with some home arrangers ideas. She said that art was a bouquet of flowers; like a rainbow, and everything did not need to match. Beauty blends with nature.

Cobalt blue was everywhere in Bubby's home. It made her happy to gaze at brilliant colors, even though Feng-shui teachers did not always agree with her selections. Her family room boasted of her brood with many photos displayed on the walls. Even though the frames differed in size and texture, they were tastefully placed. Her home looked and felt "lived-in" and "loved-in," and expressed beauty and fun.

What about the car mentioned in that motto? Did it have importance? I believe it did, Bubby earned it in her nutrition business, and when it got a little old, she gave it to one of her great grandkids who were responsible and had recently received a driver's license.

Then she bought a purple Porsche (good old bank account again) and drove it until a few years ago. Later, she hired a good-looking young driver who took her to her favorite spots, mostly to thrift stores and garage sales.

My Bubby was a good old girl. She was not afraid to make fun of herself and she dearly loved people. She would always spot the shy ones and converse with them. Her goal was to make them laugh and to like themselves a little more.

I'm told that I take after my great-great grandma. My name is Stella El-Hai, which translates to Princess Starlight, the living goddess. Here's looking at you Bubby. Don't mess things up too much up there...only just a little. We love you!

Macho Mama

Our garage might as well have had a sign on it, "Sam's Hardware Outlet." Have you ever known a true pack rat who was organized and neat? That statement comes from pride, not exacerbation. If a neighbor wanted to borrow some #492 screws or a 2/3-inch washer, Sam could locate them in seconds. The lids of Gerber baby food jars were screwed on to shelves with visible nuts and bolts inside them. Nails and screws of every size were placed in little bins. Even scrap wood was lovingly arranged in an open box near the power saw. I found these pieces so fascinating, that I made a collage of them. It brought in a blue ribbon at an art show!

In those early years of marriage, the fixit jobs were delegated to the husband, although I often assisted and helped my partner. On the other hand, I became the cook and child bearer, but my mate made Sunday breakfasts with his "home grown" sour dough, and always did special things with the kids.

So, we learned from each other by being there with an open mind and loving heart. Shortly before he died, Sam reviewed special instructions as to our finances, how to regulate the sprinkler system, how to take care of the swimming pool, etc., etc. Some of these guidelines did not register too well as I was completely involved with taking care of my thoughtful spouse. Little did I realize how, through osmosis, many of his traits were imbedded in my subconscious.

Three years after Sam's passing, I moved to Sun City. There were many situations where an imaginative handyman would have been greatly appreciated. That was when an imaginative and feisty handygal was born. Luckily, I chose not to sell one of Sam's big, red tool lockers, nor his sturdy aluminum ladder, in the huge garage sale I had before relocating.

It was reassuring to learn that there was a group in Sun City called the Foundation. The purpose of this organization was to help residents with chores and various "handyman" activities. At first, this was a relief to discover. However, when a fluorescent bulb went out, the Wife of Sam took charge and replaced it herself. Perhaps it was a little unwise of me to climb the ladder and complete the mission, but it certainly felt good that I was capable.

Since then, there have been numerous occasions when I have flexed my "chutzpah" muscle and have taken on a task that had a "male" label on it. I'll give you an example: Several weeks ago, I stayed at a lovely hotel that had a pullout magnifying mirror on the bathroom wall. It was so easy to see exactly what I was doing while applying my makeup, plucking a stray hair from my eyebrow, etc. Wouldn't I love to own one of these mirrors at home! The search began and I soon found just what I was looking for. It even came with the proper screws and instructions. My trusty electric screwdriver made the holes for me and voila, I am enjoying my new device so much; can't you tell?

More accomplishments...In the showers of the locker rooms, the showerheads are portable with various choices of sprays, pulses and pressure. The one I had at home was sort of wimpy, and I longed for the other. The search was on and I finally found the one I preferred. Now that I had it home, I had to remove the old one and install the replacement, hopefully with no drips or leaks. I opened my "Do it Herself" tool kit and located the proper thingamajig that would undo the whatchamacallit. Although I got a little moist during procedure, and emotions had nothing to do with it, I was able to get the new showerhead tightly attached. There were no leaks! I crossed my

fingers and turned the water on. It sprayed to beat the band. When I shut it off, there was nothing that resembled the Chinese torture system. It's so wonderful, I sometimes shower twice a day!

I have a friend (I have lots more since I'm showering twice a day.) who is of the masculine persuasion. Although he is very talented in a given field, he is the unhandiest guy I know. As a new resident here, there were zillions of chores that needed doing. When he asked me for my "artistic" advice on where to hang his pictures, I kindly obliged. Little did I know that not only did he appreciate my aesthetic input, but he had the ladder, nails, measuring tape, and six pictures ready for the El-Hai touch. Oh well, what is friendship for? Besides, I was later treated to a great dinner at the Chinese Seafood Buffet, which made up for the calories I lost climbing up and down the ladder.

The latest commodity that tickled my fancy was a stand up hat rack to house the many zany hats I have acquired for countless shows and programs. It was a pity to hide them in a closet when they wanted to brazenly decorate my humble abode and dazzle my guests. Garage sales were not fruitful and the website prices were unattractive. 'Lo and behold, Linens and Things featured what I sought, plus a five dollar coupon. Of course, it came in a box with instructions. It now stands proudly in my family room, and I swear the feathers wave at me when I pass by.

So, my father was right when he shared, "If it can be done, you can do it, only better." I don't know about the "better" part, but it feels great to be a macho mama.

Less than a Penny

It was torture that I looked forward to each winter. For half the year I succumbed to bribes and threats, willingly.

"If you clean up my side of the room, I'll take you to Steeplechase when it opens," said my older sister, my master.

When it was her turn to wash the floors, guess who did it? It was as if I were a kid-Cinderella, sternly directed by my senior sister, who knew she had the upper hand. Until that wonderland of joy and rides opened in early summer, I was an accommodating slave to Bunny, who said that she would take me to that pinnacle of delight, in Coney Island, *if* I did this and that, and everything in the world for her. She was almost four years older than I and she had a handle on my hot button.

It's important that you visualize Steeplechase from the mind of a ten year old. After taking the subway to Coney Island, you would walk; no, run, to the huge entrance. For fifty cents, you would receive a circular ticket with fifty-one numbers around the circumference. Each number represented a ride. Can you imagine fifty-one fabulous rides for fifty cents? That's less than a penny per ride! The corresponding number was punched out at the entrance of the ride and a person could be entertained all day long.

Now these were not ordinary rides. One of my favorites was a slide that was three stories high. After climbing to the top, you looked down at a huge, wavy glide that ended in a circular basin. You would speed round and round before you decelerated and breathlessly exited. There was also a carousel that consisted of swings. As the speed increased, the swings became horizontal to the floor. It was impossible not to scream. Of course, there was the rollercoaster, which was deliciously scary too.

We also had a method of securing extra tickets for free so that we could repeat our favorite thrillers. One of the events was a large theater-style auditorium. People (mostly men) would sit and watch the unsuspecting performers, enter the stage area from another doorway. Oftentimes, they came from the swimming pool area and were eager to continue their day of fun. The greeter at the entry escorted his guests to a gate on the stage. When they passed through, compressed air from the floor would mimic a famous Marilyn Monroe scene. A wary customer would try to back away, only to be "encouraged" with the electric prod used by the welcomer. Many men got their jollies for hours and gladly donated their tickets to us.

One spring, when I was twelve years old, a miracle happened. I was now the same height as my sister and felt quite mature. My mother said that I could go, with my friends, to the land of pleasure and excitement. No more threats or slave tactics. And yet a strange thing happened during that time. As I developed from a child into young womanhood, Bunny and I became very close. She became my mentor, advisor and buddy. We went shopping for clothes together and often borrowed from each other. When I wanted to try out for the cheering squad at our mutual high school, Bunny, who was already on the team, coached me and gave me some valuable pointers. She was as proud as I was when I was accepted.

My sister is still my very close and loving friend, with whom I have a great rapport. Those memories of Steeplechase are priceless and are worth much more than a penny or less.

Junior Miss-Take

Vera, a very outspoken but wise woman, told me, shortly before my adventurous move from New York to California, that my friends would miss me more than I would miss them. At the tender age of 15, that was difficult for me to believe. After all, I had been with the same "crowd" of girls practically all of my life. My special pals and I were very close, and had been from the fifth grade on to my fifteenth year. But Vera said with her wise eyes, and a pointed index finger, "Just wait and see."

The first summer, I was thrilled to get a job at Paramount Studios, as a script girl. Even though it paid only 60 cents per hour, I learned skills that helped me in the future. I mimeographed the scripts, and learned how to collate and bundle them. A bicycle delivery to various sets was the next step. Bing Crosby and Fred Astaire were rehearsing "Blue Skies" and I lingered as long as I could. I tried to eat my lunch close to Diana Lynn's bungalow, so that I could listen to her play the piano. You can imagine how my girlfriends screamed when I gave them the glorious details.

During the semester, I worked at Sears, in the fudge department! The pay was a little better, but the temptations were too great and at my young age, my contours and complexion were extremely important. It was strange making new pals. They liked me, but said that I talked funny. When I took a drama class at Fairfax High, we each had to make a recording of our voice, and I was shocked to hear my Brooklyn accent, and how rapidly I spoke. Funny indeed! It was tragic. New York did give me an advantage however. Academically, the eastern schools were more advanced; we had been taking three semesters a year. So I skipped another semester, and graduated at age 16.

The winter holiday break before graduation gave me another chance for an interesting job. This story drove my Brooklyn friends absolutely wild! Teenagers were sought after to help out in many downtown, Los Angeles stores, just before the Christmas holidays. A very nice, smart woman hired me as a saleslady in her lovely dress store. She even promised me a discount on anything that I wanted for myself. During an exceptionally busy evening, a couple approached me and said that they wanted to buy a wardrobe for their favorite niece, who was my size. Would I model some outfits for them? My boss said, "Absolutely" and whispered, "Put on the prettiest, most expensive outfits."

My friends would go insane. The clothing was heavenly, and even with a double discount, I could never afford them. But for a while, I truly felt like a royal princess. Five dresses later, the man and woman beckoned to me, and handed me a business card. They apologized and confessed that they didn't really have a niece but that they were talent scouts searching for unknown actors for a coming movie called "Junior Miss." Now this was all very exciting, but my New York brain reminded me of con-people who posed as talent scouts, and want to give you a screen test. And that's exactly what they said was their plan. I took the business card and told them I would let them know.

When school began the following week, I spoke to Miss Jamgochian, my drama teacher. Her eyes widened as she read the card, and she became very animated. "Oh, this is great. I know William Morris and he is one of the best. I'll coach you and we can work on this together."

I wrote four letters to the east coast that night, and surely caused at least two of my girlfriends to faint. My brother, who was in the

theatrical world, took me to the John Reed photographic studio to get glossy professional pictures, which were required. Mr. Morris was very pleased with the results and said he would set up a date for the screen test.

The next week, he phoned me and said that the actress, Joan Bennett, had purchased the film rights and wanted known actors in it. Mona Freeman got the part that was meant for me, and my best girlfriend, Lucy, in New York, had a nervous breakdown (almost).

When I think of what might have been, I'm actually very grateful that I grew up to be a normal, stable, lovable girl/woman. But Vera was right. While my Brooklynese girlfriends were in a constant frenzy, I studied my courses at Los Angeles City College, married my dream man at 18, and had four drug-free, non-neurotic, absolutely wonderful kids. I'll never regret it, but Lucy does.

It's Greek to Me!

The reviews on the movie, "My Big Fat Greek Wedding" were not that great, but friends who had seen it told me how delightful it was, so I went with a few pals to view it. I, too, found it to be very entertaining, and it brought back several incidents of my past "Greek history."

Sam's mother, two of his sisters, and a five-year-old niece, were the only El-Hais who traveled from New York to attend our wedding in Los Angeles. Although they are wonderful people, they stayed with us, in our home, for six weeks after our honeymoon!! My stubborn Greek father-in-law wouldn't attend any wedding because he didn't believe that rabbis should get paid for their services. But that's another story.

Six months later, during the summer, we decided to drive cross-country, see the wonderful sights, and visit the rest of Sam's family in New York. Like the movie, the large family consisted of his grandparents Ya Ya and Papoo, more siblings, and jillions of aunts, uncles and cousins. A gala reception would follow our arrival, and I certainly wanted to make a good impression. To help bring that about, my dear husband taught me a lovely Greek phrase that I practiced over and over. He said that I would endear myself to the whole family if I expressed it with emotion. I visualized that tearful hugs of welcome would follow. What did I know!

The eventful day finally arrived and before the sumptuous meal began, Sam proudly introduced me and declared that I had become a Greek scholar and had a sincere wish to share. They all applauded as I stood up, and with arms outstretched proclaimed, "Tsa klahnes alla nichta!" Stark silence ... open mouths ... My surprise turned into bewilderment as the family then roared with laughter and

slapped their knees. I looked at Sam who was sputtering into his glass of ouzo.

One of his sisters finally confessed that my dear spouse had taught me to say—how can I put it nicely?—"You should relieve yourself from gaseous pressures all night long!" Strangely enough, it did endear me to them.

The never-ending dinner that my wonderful mother-in-law, Sarina, prepared, was absolutely delicious. However, the chicken soup had what looked like mushrooms floating on top.

"Are these mushrooms in the soup Mom?" I queried.

"Eat, eat, I'll tell you later," was her reply.

The mushrooms were creamy with a crunchy edge, and I later learned that they were a Greek delicacy; sliced chicken heads with a brain center. I have mastered many Greek dishes, excluding that one.

Ya Ya also wished to teach the newcomer a Greek thing or two. She served Sam and me her special Greek coffee, served in delicate demitasse cups. Not only was it my first cup of Greek coffee, it was my first cup of any coffee. The liquid was thick and sweet (glyco), and the few sips I enjoyed before I reached the "mud," were tasty. Ya Ya put the tiny saucer over the cup and quickly reversed it, to allow the grinds to drip to the small plate, forming various patterns in the cup. She repeated this procedure with Sam's cup. After a minute or two, the cups were set right side up so that our "fortunes" could be read. Ya Ya examined the patterns, and clapped her hands together, as she gazed upwards. She hugged us both, kissed our cheeks, and said in Greek, "One pattern; one heart!" It seems that Sam and I had almost identical impressions. I quickly learned this maneuver, and together with a wild imagination and some "chutzpah," I have

teased and fascinated many acquaintances. In fact, after reading a gentleman's cup, he asked me to advise him on stock options!

Within a few days, I'm expecting an exciting visit from my eleven-year-old granddaughter, Sarina, from Seattle. She is the easiest child to plan meals for. Sarina loves all kinds of vegetables, salads, fruits, (except mangoes), and doesn't have the usual hangups of many kids. When I asked her if she had any requests for meals, she replied, "I love your soups Bubby."

"Great! How about a hearty chicken soup?" I asked.

"That's fine with me Bubby, but please leave out the mushrooms."

"No mushrooms Sweetie. I promise."

Gasoline Alley

During my youth, Saturday nights were highlighted with my favorite radio thrillers, "The Witches Tale," "Gang Busters," "The Shadow," or "The Lone Ranger." To lighten up the atmosphere, there was always Cecile B. de Mille's "Lux Theater" and the ever popular, "Hit Parade." The top ten song hits were played and sung starting with number ten. My friends and I would guess which the top three would be, and we all had the lyrics down pat.

Sunday mornings presented another special routine. The New York Daily News, Sunday edition, had the best "jokes." Today, they are called "comics" or "funnies." How we looked forward to Li'l Abner, Tillie the Toiler, Smilin' Jack and Dick Tracy. I never liked Little Orphan Annie because she never changed her dress and her wide-open oval eyes made her look like an idiot. But I was intrigued with Gasoline Alley. It was a family story with people who advanced rapidly to an older age. Within four months, all the characters were a year older. The babies quickly developed into toddlers who were ready for school within weeks. The father's hair began to thin while the mother's tummy got plumper and she soon required glasses.

Why am I reminiscing about old time comic strips? It's because I felt like I was living in the fast paced Gasoline Alley era during our recent annual family reunion. This year we located in Corona, off the shores of North Carolina. Hurricane Charley paid us a visit and delayed our gathering for a day. However, sunny days and happy times followed along with that feeling that I was once again part of the scene where calendar pages flew off rapidly. Only this time, it was real.

My youngest granddaughter, little Sasha was now an adorable, capable four year old, with whom I could converse. No longer last years thumb sucking baby of cuteness. Her six-year-old sister, Natalie

developed into a darn good comedienne, and took over our family talent show. She closely resembled her father, sans beard, who closely resembles me, also sans beard. Going up the ladder, eight-year-old Coly advanced into a young woman with an interesting attitude. If she didn't feel like speaking, she wouldn't. However, she could pick up any adult textbook and read it flawlessly. She had become a good swimmer and was able to take care of herself with confidence.

The teen team, Sarina and Leaf, had become budding women with impressive buds. Three months apart and pushing fourteen, their talent in art, dance and voice was apparent. It was easy to visualize them quickly slipping into womanhood, each with their own version of attraction and talents.

As for the two cool dude male grandkids, Forest had grown higher with a lower voice registry. Almost sixteen years old with a necessary pronounced swagger to hold up his falling trousers. Four inches of his $30 red satin shorts were on display with "red, hot peppers" written all over them. Would next year have him swagger even more in order to prevent a possible police raid? Wren was almost eighteen and had become the giant of the family. His mind was on college, living away from home, taking Russian and a fascinating schedule of difficult subjects. We were all a-buzz over his recent championship of the national quiz bowl in Orlando.

Could Robin, the lovely queen of grandkids, freshly graduated from high school, really be ready for driving? Her job of lifeguard at the local pool would pay for the insurance and gas of a future new/old car. Luckily, the chlorine did not turn her honey gold hair green.

My wonderful four children and their respective spouses looked the same, didn't they? But wait; there were some gray patches in

Jeff's beard. And "baby" Jack lost his rounded pouch, twenty pounds worth. Even Laurisa and Joline had sprouted a few more silver strands, trying to catch up with their momma.

Time had not stood still for the matriarch either. Not too long ago, I had hiked up the hills with the best of them. This year, I chose the trolley car instead. I was commanded to occupy the best and most convenient bedroom in the huge three-story house…I was being treated like a senior citizen…Good or bad, that's the way it was, and is.

Yes, the clock ticks faster, the wonderful days fly, as do the weeks and months. But would I want it any other way? Next year, there will be new developments, more mature children and a few surprises. As long as we can savor the precious moments of today, the delightful memories of tomorrow are sure to follow. Please slow down a bit Gasoline Alley. Take a rest, and I will too.

Forever Amber, Part 2

Let's get this straight from the start. This is not a steamy story about some courtesans or racy women. It's better. Think orange-gold, think liquid sunsets, think deliciously happy. Before you understand my fascination with the color amber, I need to tell you about my aunt Eva.

Just before the start of the First World War, my nineteen-year-old mother, Bella, met, fell in love with, and married my father, Jack Siegel, the oldest son of Gussie and Sam. Just about the same time, Jack's younger brother, Otto, a real hunk, met and married fifteen-year-old Eva. Both brides were recent immigrants from Russia and Rumania. Fortunately, the Yiddish language was the common tongue that was known to the whole family, and throughout the world. Jack's four sisters were crude and unkind to the newcomers and mimicked their foreign accents. After all, the sisters had been Americans for a few years and made fun of the greenhorns.

It was easy for Bella and Eva to bond and become confidants. Interestingly though, they also became competitors. Whose baby would be fatter? Weight was a sign of prosperity and food in the house. Eva, spooned Vaseline* into Edna, her chubby daughter's mouth. Bella's daughter, Boscalah, AKA Bernice, or "Boiniss" later changed her name to Bunny, had to be backed up against the wall to eat some of her egg. She was a finicky eater, much to Bella's dismay.

It was a time of poverty and the depression. Families lived close together to "lend" each other bread, food, and support. Although children were loved and were a source of pride and joy, unexpected pregnancies were not celebrated. Birth control was not generally known and the size of families was often controlled by abortions. A midwife often performed the procedure but when Eva realized that she was expecting again, the midwife was not available.

Bella took her to a male "doctor" who was able to help. He was called upon frequently in the community, and one was lucky to get the service of a safe and clean medic. Leaning on her friend, after the episode, Eva slowly walked back to her apartment and weakly fell into bed. Bella then began to prepare some nourishment for Eva and her family.

When Otto arrived, he comforted his wife until he learned who the performing doctor was. In a jealous frenzy, he grabbed a kitchen knife and leaped towards his wife. Screaming at the top of her lungs, Bella pushed herself between husband and wife, and with outstretched arms shouted, "Kill me instead!" Otto relented and replaced the knife. He lit his cigarette, approached the bed again, and pushed the burning weapon into Eva's arm. It was almost like a melodrama in the days of silent films. The scar lasted a long time.

During that day, I had a melodrama of my own. My older siblings were in school, but I was only two and needed to be cared for. It was necessary for me to be placed in a community day care center. I remember crying for my mama, and when I didn't quiet down, I was placed into a locked, dark closet for the remainder of the day. What would Dr. Laura have to say about that??

My aunt Eva was a super housekeeper. My nose rebelled against the smell of Clorox and ammonia whenever I visited her. But her place was immaculate and literally shone. I loved to see her bathroom because the enamel sink sparkled and there was no dust anywhere. Once, when I visited her lavatory, the sun made everything glisten even brighter. Above the sink, there were two amber toothbrushes, hanging and spotlighted by the sunbeams. The clean, transparent beauty of that luminous gold mesmerized my seven-year-old body. It set off my imagination and gave me a warm satisfaction that I still feel today when I gaze at that color.

Eva's shiny dark eyes and vivacious spirit will be long remembered. That wonderful pioneering health nut introduced me to wheat germ and yogurt. When, as a twelve year old, I was troubled with menstrual cramps, Eva would rub my belly with alcohol and then place a warm towel over it.

She lived to be ninety-two, but my memories of her will always have a golden aura, surrounding the spirit of a warm, vibrant woman.

* As a matter of interest, I just came upon an article about Robert Augustus Chesebrough, who invented Vaseline. The name of the product was derived from the German/Greek words for water and olive oil, and was a miracle cure for many ailments in the 1860's. The inventor ate a spoonful of the stuff every morning to prolong his life. He lived to be 96. Perhaps Aunt Eva's motivation was not only to fatten up her child, but also to insure better health. One can only guess.

Calling on Kodak

How many times have you been in a special place or situation, and have wished you had a camera to capture the moment? During my married years, Sam was the family photographer. He had several complicated cameras, tripods, filters, timers, automatic this and that, and all the patience in the world. During our vacations, which were usually camping experiences, the kids would get exasperated when their Dad would want them to gather for photos. Now, they and their families treasure the excellent recall of their growing years, and the breathtaking view of the surroundings that went along with it.

Cameras and pictures were Sam's domain and when I wanted to seize and "memorize" the moment, I learned to do just that in my own way. In fact, I can go back to pre-Sam days and visit my personal memory album:

A Nickel for a Pickle

I was less than five years old and living in the ghetto called Brownsville, in Brooklyn, New York. The neighborhood teamed with immigrants from all over the world, and customs were crude, but accepted. There was an old lady (she probably wasn't more than forty years old), with a black dress and a black shawl over her head. She was ambling down the crowded street, gumming on a big pickle. I suppose I was staring at her because she stopped, smiled, (her gums were purple!) and offered me a bite. I turned and ran so quickly that I bumped into a gypsy with a green satin skirt.

Treasures in the Sand

It always took us extra long to get to Coney Island, because as many times as we had driven there, my father always blundered. My

mother would say, "Jack, turn right at the next light." But macho Papa turned left. I must have inherited my no sense of direction from my father, but at least he had a car and knew how to drive it; well, almost. But we always would get to the beach eventually and begin our day of marvelous fun. The sand along the east coast was always silky smooth, and a delight to walk on, except when it was an exceptionally hot day, and your feet would blister and burn. After we settled down and Mama would spread the blanket, I began digging in the dunes until I reached the moist, cool ground. Inevitably, I would spot something shiny. It was a penny! My excavating took on a rapid pace. There was another penny, and a nickel. I was so excited, and was able to buy an ice-cream dip for my sister and myself. I later learned that my wonderful parents planted the coins for our fun and jubilation.

In Full Charge

I was thirteen when my mother and older sister decided to check out California, to see if it was all that it was cracked up to be. My father had his used furniture store to care for, and I had my high school classes to attend to. During the two weeks that they were gone, I took care of our home in East Flatbush, and the meals. For the first time, I directed the men, who filled up our heater with oil, as to where in the basement to go. It was wonderful to be the boss, and everything went smoothly. My father wanted to surprise my mother with a baby grand piano, when she returned. We decorated it with a huge red bow, and placed the long streamers down the steps, and outside, all the way down the alley to the sidewalk. It was awesome to watch my mom when she arrived and followed the red ribbons all the way to her heart's dream....a baby grand piano! She screamed;

she cried; she laughed and danced. Then, my father lifted her onto his shoulders and did a wild Jack Siegel dance. When my mother finally focused on me, I got a big hug for a job well done, and only a slightly raised eyebrow for my newly acquired fuchsia lipstick.

Lots of Bottles

On New Years day, right after my fifteenth birthday, my eighteen-year-old sister and I boarded the train to go to the land of sunshine and movie stars. My parents needed to stay behind to sell the house and furniture store. I had to be on time to start my last year of high school. It was a four-day adventure, filled with a little fright because the train was loaded with servicemen who would be continuing on to the South Pacific. In our Pullman bed, we heard the constant rolling and crashing of the beer bottles down the aisle. Some of the guys were cute, but mama's index finger was foremost in our minds, and we looked at the scenery and read lots of books.

The Hollywood Canteen

I was underage, but I volunteered to help serve doughnuts and coffee to the men of our armed forces. It was urgent that I see the entertaining stars, so that I could write the news to my girlfriends in Brooklyn. Besides, I wanted to dance with some of those handsome soldiers and sailors. I met and jitterbugged with three of my New Yorker high school chums, who wanted a special date before they shipped out. It was sad, but meaningful. Furthermore, I got to go to Earl Carroll's and meet Jimmy Durante and his pianist, Eddie Jackson.

The Look

When the war was over, and Sam and I decided to tie the knot, we had a lovely wedding and reception. It was January 13, and one of the luckiest days of my life. Our honeymoon took place at the Windmere Hotel in Santa Monica. We were too excited to eat the wedding dinner and when we arrived at the hotel, we were famished. We lingered at the hotel restaurant, nibbled on sandwiches and then decided to go to our reserved room, number 312. Finally, we gathered our belongings and approached our room. Sam leaned forward as he inserted the key, turned his head with a mysterious smile, and gave me "the look." That's a picture I can easily retrieve at any time.

Flipping through my album of "mind pictures," I see adorable babies, sunsets with my family, sitting at the breakfast table after the kids have left for school, and relishing the quiet cup of coffee, and the field of golden daffodils outside. Helping Sam in the dark room, while he developed his priceless endowments on the best Kodak paper, didn't give me an inkling as to the treasures of gifts that I was accumulating for future joy and appreciation. Thank you Sam; thank you Kodak; thank you sweet memories.

Just before Valentine's Day this year, I decided to celebrate that loving holiday in a big way...I had a heart attack. I was not aware at the time what was happening to me as women experience this event in unique ways, so I learned.

It might be beneficial for women to recognize the variations in case they decide to honor that February occasion in a memorable way. I awoke at 5 A.M. with cold sweats, nausea, and a mild pressure on my chest. "Why did I have that delicious Chinese lunch yesterday?" were my thoughts. I tried cold compresses, hot compresses, hot tea, walking, resting, sitting. The symptoms persisted. Finally after three hours, I tried my famous power nap. After a half hour rest, the awful symptoms eased up and I was ready to face the day.

That evening, my devoted daughter, Laurisa, (the nurse practitioner) phoned to see how things were going.

"Everything is fine now, but I had a very strange morning." I proceeded to describe my uncomfortable episode.

"What did the doctor say?" she queried.

"Oh, I'm fine now, no need to run to the doctor," I answered.

"Mom, I'm coming over right now, I want a doctor to check you."

"I promise to go in the morning; not to worry," said the wise mother.

"I'm coming right over," said the stubborn daughter.

The stubborn daughter arrived at 10:30 P.M. and whisked me to the Kaiser E.R.. I had never been to an emergency room before and therein lies at least two more stories. After a relatively short wait, about an hour, I was given a blood test. Interestingly enough, certain enzyme levels determine whether or not your heart has been traumatized. Mine were elevated, and a hospital bed was ordered for me. However, they were all taken, and so Laurisa and I waited, with several other

victims, for an available bed. My stubborn but tired daughter finally left me at 4:30 A.M. when she was assured that I would be transferred in "a little while." During a much-needed mini-doze, a nurse woke me to tell me that my stay at the E.R. would cost $3,000. I couldn't believe her cheerful, "Have a nice rest!" She evidently woke the wrong person as I never was billed that outrageous fee. They don't surprise you months later, do they?

The "little while" arrived a few hours later when I was wheeled in my bed to the next destination, the hospital room. Liquids only were indicated on my chart in case I needed surgical intervention. More tests and shots followed, and I tried to get a little nap, power or not, in between. No such luck. I even looked forward to the broth and Jell-O as I knew they wouldn't shoot me while I ate (drank). There was no pain during this time, and I almost felt guilty getting all this attention.

The attending medic said that I could have solids the next morning, as surgery was not indicated. When my breakfast arrived, I was taken aback at the meal. Scrambled eggs, bacon, hash brown potatoes, white toast and jelly. It was enough to give anyone a heart attack. But I was really hungry so I devoured it. Soon, a nurse visited me with a pamphlet on a proper diet for a cardiac patient.

"You should really tell the hospital dietician that my breakfast was almost dangerous for any hospital patient," I ventured to her.

"I *am* the hospital dietician." she declared firmly, "And you'll be glad to know, there was no salt in the eggs." She did not become my life-long friend.

After my gourmet meal, I experienced an echogram. That was very interesting because I was able to see and hear my ventricles do

their job. The nurse kept giggling and when I asked her to share her mirth, she asked if I had just eaten. She then allowed me to listen to the amplified sounds of my satiated but insulted stomach. It sounded like an old fashioned, broken washing machine. I remember how my Lamaze students laughed when they heard their unborn kidlings frolic in the amniotic fluids. Interestingly enough, recordings of these gurgling, swish-crashing sounds were very soothing to the infants later on. Some smart cookie made a fortune selling these tapes. Parents of colicky babies will try anything in order to get a bit of rest. As would I during my three day vacation at the Kaiser Klassy Kamp.

Restful sleep was an unreachable, misty memory. Nurses are diligently trained to watch their patients nod off, give them thirty seconds to sink deeply, and then cheerfully surprise them with a blood pressure check, a blood thinner shot, or some medications to chug-a-lug. They would receive extra kudos if all three were administered at the same time. A nasal oxygen tube was placed and if I moved my face to the right, my eye would receive a cool blast of air. Numerous other attachments adorned me and when the phone rang, the medical staff made bets as to which would get me first... another heart attack or tubular strangulation.

Did I mention the noise? Some of those jokes must have been good ones because the laughter was amplified at 2 A.M.. Doors slamming, shoes squeaking and clicking, loudspeaker messages from one desk to another. Home sweet home was becoming an unreachable star.

But after three years, I mean days, I was released because of good behavior. My first desire was to languor in my wonderful bed with the soothing quiet of Sun City. It's true that "To ER(r) is Human, But to Sleep is Devine."

The Stubborn Greek

The neighbors' stolen flowers were for me, and the Hershey chocolate bars for the children were distributed just before dinner. Only one person would do such a thing, and that was my father-in-law, also known as Pop, Grandpa, or the stubborn Greek. The kids adored this eccentric man because his philosophy was so outrageous and macho.

How many times did he quote his favorite phrase in Greek, "Everything in this world is nothing. When you die, that's it...nothing more." Another one of his famous sayings; "Women are here to take care of men and to have babies." The whole family traveled from New York to California to my wedding with their son or brother, Sam, except the stubborn Greek. He worked hard in his garment industry business, with the help of many women, but held tightly onto his earnings when asked to spend it for a family cause.

Abraham Elhai was shocked when Sam and I refused to accept his offer of $100 per month while Sam finished up his college education. We (stubbornly?) decided that with the G.I. Bill and a job for me, we could make it just fine without feeling obligated to Pop. And we did. I worked as a medical doctor's girl Friday and learned to give painless injections, diathermy treatments, x-rays, make appointments, collect fees, etc. At the same time, I wanted desperately to make an impression on Pop when he finally sold his business and joined his family in California. He rented a shop in East Los Angeles, and with several sewing machines and Latinas, began making aprons, pajamas, and a New York version of a blanket cover, which was unknown in California.

With the steady and rapid flow of east coast newcomers, I knew that the blanket covers could be a big item. I offered to try to get

orders for his merchandise, and he ridiculed a nineteen year old, a female, for even considering this and me. With gritting teeth, I set out to show him what a woman could do. I made an appointment with the buyer of J.C. Penny's and he was willing to give the blanket covers a try. That began a steady stream of orders for many years. Did I get a thank you? Are you kidding?

My determination to win him over never diminished. Sarina, my sweet mother-in-law, patiently taught me many wonderful Greek dishes, which I still cook today. When Pop tasted my delicacies, he'd laugh and say, "This isn't the way my mother made it in Crete!" Of course, he would then proceed to clean the plate with a piece of bread. I'm not the only one he singled out. His wife and daughters got the same treatment. He did not know how to be kind and affectionate to adults, only to little children. Once the kids reached his height, about five feet two inches, they became the butt of his sarcasm too.

Pop built a good business on Brooklyn Avenue in Boyle Heights. Because he was Sephardic, he spoke Spanish fluently and was well liked by his Latina customers. He custom fit some very large clients with cotton housedresses and only charged for the material. When grandchildren visited his shop, they got to play with boxes of buttons and other hardware. He had his fun side. Once a young man came into the store and demanded cash. Abraham said, pointing to the old fashioned, bulky cash register:

"You want the money? Go ahead and take it."

The thief grinned and grabbed the heavy register and began sprinting down the street, with Abraham flailing his arms, right behind him. The culprit slowed down and began limping as the threatening hernia became evident. In the end, the heavy machine

was dropped and Abraham had lots of cheers and help getting it back to the shop.

In certain areas, he earned high praise. He taught himself to play the mandolin and used to entertain relatives and neighbors on New York stoops. When a sewing machine needle went through his right index finger, and caused permanent rigidity, he gave up his wonderful playing. Did he give the Cretan mandolin to one of his musically gifted children? No way! Demanding Aunt Marika got it and most likely sold it. On the other hand, he was a super storyteller. He remembered the days of his youth, when he stole aboard a Turkish ship to try to get out of being entrapped into the Greek army. War broke out between the Turks and the Greeks (again!) while he was on board, and he had to run for his life. Even at age 95, his recall was tremendous.

Once, in the middle of the night, he phoned us and said, "How come the sun went out? Everything is dark and people are afraid to come outside; the streets are very quiet." We told him we would check into this, but in the meantime, he should try to take a long nap.

Sam and I had the most patience with him. With Sarina gone, the other siblings tried to help him but his insults were too much for them and their spouses. With his consent, we secured a room for him, in a senior hotel on Melrose Avenue. He immediately complained that the place was filled with old people. At the time, he was still walking blocks to catch buses, although he retired at age 96. He claimed that the automobile business was money hungry, and refused to support the industry.

The area he lived in soon became a bustling, funky hangout. Clothing shops featured models with spiked hair and shiny leather mini skirts. Pop noticed a shop across the street that featured tapes and films, and he qualified to enter, as they required adult customers only.

"Do you have something in Greek?" he inquired.

"We sure do Pops. Just step in the back."

When he emerged, red-faced and using all the special Greek cuss words I had been taught, he shouted with his rigid pointed finger, "You sons of bitches should be ashamed of yourselves. Greek girls don't do those things. Bastards!" They lost a unique customer.

Years back, Abraham's mother, whom we called Ya Ya (grandmother) had a dream that her son would be called to the great beyond sometime in February. Dreams and premonitions were not to be taken lightly. In fact, Ya Ya taught me how to read Greek coffee grounds, and I still predict the future of many of my friends and a couple of enemies.

In January, two months before his ninety-ninth birthday, Pop was mugged while walking the Hollywood streets at night. They might have gotten $8 for their drugs from his old wallet, but Pop fell and hurt his head on the sidewalk and was hospitalized. If he was allowed to rest and not given all kinds of medication, I think he would have been too stubborn to leave just then. My son, Jeff, visited him in the hospital, placed a Hershey bar into the Greek's hand, and reminded him that he still had a month to go. Pop rallied for a while and then left. Although he believed in nothingness after death, the family feels that he is in limbo. God doesn't feel he is the right resident for Heaven, and the devil refuses to accept him too. So Abraham Elhai is floating around, insulting the angels, and giving the devil Hell.

What I Want My Children to Know (and What I Don't Want Them to Know)

Ever since my four great kids left the nest and became independent, I vowed that unless I was asked, I would not pressure them with my advice. This was especially true after they married and grew their own families. This was no easy task, verging on the unnatural, and there were times when I abused my own mouth by biting my inner cheeks and nibbling real hard on my tongue, lest I utter what I thought would have been a giant pearl of wisdom.

I was further protected from my inborn tendency to help, by the sharp whistling of my son Jack's version of, "My Yiddisha Mama." Of course, I would laugh with the others while my practical brain silently shouted, "My way is so much better, and it would save you time and money too!" But the mouth remained fused, and my ingenious suggestion floated into space with all the rest of my computer data.

Then a brilliant thought popped into my neurons. If I wrote a little story about my ideas and experiences, that wouldn't be pushy, would it? If my children chose not to read it, (they wouldn't dare!) so be it. That would be their loss; and I'd only be doing it for their good, right? Especially if I wrote about myself, and how it feels to approach advanced maturity, then there would be no fingers pointing at anyone, and my dear ones would benefit from my knowledge and expertise. So here goes....

Things happen. Take these little carbuncles that start to grow on your body. Some of my friends call them skin tags. So here's a valuable hint that even Heloise doesn't know about yet. Every night, dab some calamine lotion on the culprits and rub with a skin buffer every time you shower. It takes about a week but soon your epidermis will be soft and smooth again.

As one becomes wiser (older), the sleeping pattern changes. Sometimes, for one reason or another (mostly, the other) you get up in the wee wee hours of the morning and it's difficult to fall asleep again. I keep a small portable radio near my bedside and tune in. Some of those people who call in to the talk shows are so uninformed and boring, that I find myself dozing off before long. If that doesn't work, my trusty book is close by. Even if the novel is extremely interesting, the glare of the light and the effort of holding the book upright knocks me out within ten minutes. So, no matter what the interference, I usually wake up refreshed.

That does not stop me from taking my next miraculous recommendation, the Power Nap. Close to 2 P.M. I get firm indications that it's time to give it a rest. I remove my shoes, unhook anything binding, recline on my bed, place my "dog-bone" pillow beneath my neck, position my purple velvet eye-cover filled with lavender over my eyes, tune in to Dr. Laura on the radio, and sink into la-la land. If Dr. Laura gets too rude and obnoxious, I click her off and descend into la-la land just the same. I do my Lamaze muscle release and enjoy a sound sleep for about 45 minutes.

Fortunately, my offspring have inherited good hair, but there might come a time when special attention is indicated. I blushingly admit that several of my friends have commented that my tresses look bright and shiny, so I will share a little secret with you. Shampoo at least three times a week. Rinse and add a smidgeon of a clean smelling conditioner. Flush with warm water and gradually make the water as cold as you can without screaming. With a nice fluffy towel (that has not been treated with softener) press your hair down flat thereby beginning the drying process. The cold water compresses

the hair cuticles so that it is better able to reflect back light. Bet you didn't know that one!

My planner is my constant companion. I'm very uneasy if I misplace it because I refer to it a couple of times a day. It is my theory that if I have fun things to look forward to, my state of mind will be happier. Several times, I have overloaded my schedule, and that is very, very bad. I have learned to actually schedule spaces for me to do whatever comes to mind. This is not only calming but therapeutic. Also, I require a monthly trip to the thrift store or I will develop a deficiency, which is detrimental to my health. My lucky kids have inherited that special gene which causes one to seek bargains and treasures of unknown value. This activity is priceless and definitely elevates one's endorphins. I would put it on the same level as regular exercise or making out.

Which brings me to the subject of showing affection, and caring. Did you know that most people consider their own name to be very precious? To call the person you are speaking to, or writing about, by his/her name, is a gift. It might even be preferable to giving money, although I'm sure to get an argument on that one. It's a good idea to find a way to remember names because it's embarrassing when someone addresses you with your name and you have no idea to whom you are talking. Some people like to hug, others don't. If you're not sure, rub their back in a friendly, circular fashion. As long as your hands are clean, no one should object.

Now we come to itches, primarily those of the ear. Perhaps it's "phonitis" but I have developed a chronic itch in my right ear. It seems to flare up when it's time for bed. I have tried many ointments, lotions and even my favorite mosquito bite remedy...toothpaste. This

last idea didn't work too well, and although I smelled fresh and ready, the darn stuff flaked off onto the pillow and flunked the itch test. What to do? The challenge got very exciting, and then I spotted the Redeemer....Vicks VapoRub! What relief. I felt a warm, slight burn, which actually was quite pleasant. *Don't* try it anywhere else. I smelled antiseptically fresh but not quite ready.

Going south just a tad, I will now share with you an excellent and cheap sore throat treatment. Sarina, my Greek mother-in-law, passed this down to me. Locate a soft cloth, dish towel size, fold it so that it's about three inches wide, and saturate it with rubbing alcohol. Place it around your throat, not too tight. Cover it with a dry fabric and go to bed. This increases and localizes circulation and is very soothing. Sarina used seven star Metaxa, but the much less expensive alcohol will put you in the same euphoric state and you won't care about the sore throat anymore.

If not for my Capricorn-type husband and his organizational influence on me, I would most likely have become a ditsy Bohemian, leaping from room to room in a carefree manner. While sitting on his lap, he would gently impress me with the importance of making lists of more than I thought I would accomplish the next day. Whatever tasks remained would then be added to the following day's list. The important rule was, "Do it now, and always start with the least appealing chore." It's amazing that after the lesson, in such a cuddly situation, that I remembered anything.

Two more recommendations and then I must conclude before this turns into a novel. The first one involves food. You remember how much I love bargains? If the edibles I'm shopping for are on sale, goody, goody. But I refuse to get inferior provisions to save money.

That would not be a beneficial transaction. What enters your body, your Temple, should be the very best; your life depends on it.

The last bit of wisdom I will leave you with is to be your best friend. Be your own cheerleader and send yourself messages of encouragement and love. Your brain is a master computer and remembers everything. Aha! You thought I forgot about what I don't want my children to know? If I wrote about it, they would know!

This ends my sermon. Now that wasn't very painful, was it? Jack, stop whistling!!

Such a Deal!

The thing that really got me hooked on thrift store buying was the treasure I found when I was twelve years old. It was a long sleeved blue satin blouse that felt like liquid. Not only was it creamy and soft, but it enhanced my budding bosom, so it was an absolute must. With bated breath, I asked the woman in charge what the price was.

"For you, shaina maidel, (nice girl), you can have it for a quarter." Twenty-five cents was certainly within my budget, so I bought it and cherished it for many years to come.

Some of my friends wrinkle their noses at the thought of buying used items, but to me these discards could be my next art project or a wonderful addition to my wardrobe of costumes. It's the surprise factor, the hunt for unknown wonders, the utter satisfaction when a friend seriously asks if I bought my blouse at Nordstrom's.

I must admit that the semi annual parking lot sale increases my heart beat as the date approaches. And because my metabolism is accelerated, I feel obligated to attend in order to keep up with my fitness program. There is no shopping list that accompanies me, only the absolute knowledge that out there in that mass of chaos are gems waiting to be rescued.

There has got to be a "bargain" gene that is passed down from generation to generation. My father, who was in the used furniture business, was able to assess a home full of furniture and offer a fair price. But what he really saw were a few raw "diamonds" that could be polished up to bring in a profitable sum. My mother had the flair for redesigning a dress to make the perfect costume for a school play. She freely gave her time in discussing, and sewing for her children because she was generous and wanted to share in the fun of the production.

All of my four kids savor the search for good deals and are especially enthusiastic if their spouses are happy to accompany them. At family reunions, we do one-upmanships to see who got the best buy.

Part of the art of being a successful shopper is knowing how to haggle properly. Some sellers are disappointed not to engage in this friendly sport as they really wish to get rid of their merchandise. This brings to mind a recent experience with freckles, or what some uncouth people call "age spots," or worse yet, "liver (ugh!) spots."

While window-shopping at the Galleria Mall, (I do buy retail on rare occasion), a lovely young vendor, who represented Mary Kay's cosmetics, beckoned my friend and me to try for a free product. I won a waterproof mascara, which would come in handy for my water aerobics class.

"What else might you be interested in? I'd be happy to deliver it along with the free mascara." she offered.

"Do you have anything that will safely fade away freckles?" I inquired, showing her my hand.

"I'm sure we have a product that will do the job. Would next Tuesday afternoon be convenient?"

The following Tuesday, the lovely agent arrived with several samples, a tiny tube of freckle fading creme, and apologies that the mascara had not yet arrived but would be delivered with my next order. The freckle creme cost $28, lasted two weeks, and didn't work.

My metabolism proceeded to increase, so I knew a good garage sale was coming. Another bargain freak and I scouted around, and amidst the possibilities, there on the table was a brand new jar of a freckle creme I had seen on TV called, "Miracle Creme." On TV the six ounce jar cost $18.95 and it included a wide slotted toaster that could handle

fat bagels, plus free shipping. I really didn't need another toaster, and the whole thing sounded like a scam to me. But here it was on the under one dollar table, without the toaster to be sure, and with a price tag of seventy-five cents.

"Would you take a quarter?" I asked sweetly.

"You bet! Can you use a toaster for a dollar fifty?"

I declined the generous offer and paid my debt. Everyone was happy, and the freckles are fading. Episodes like this build and restore one's faith in man and womankind.

Another exciting find at the parking lot sale in Sun City, was an irregularly shaped slice of a large tree. Most people would see this as a possible stepping-stone in a garden, but I envisioned an unusual painting on my living room wall. It was cumbersome and heavy and the seller was glad to get rid of it for two dollars. I do occasionally venture into the higher figures. My home is now blessed with a Jackson Pollack-type painting of museum quality, and if you don't believe it, come up and see me sometimes!

This activity can add a new dimension to your life, if you find it enticing. Should you say to yourself, "Who needs more junk in my house? I'm ready to give a bunch away! I'd rather go to a clean, orderly place, tell the clerk the size, color and style that I have in mind, and have her fetch it for me," then this markdown market and possible bonanza is not for you. If, on the other hand, you have the itch to explore and love the element of surprise, plus you want to enrich your fitness program, then give it a go.... believe me, you'll get used to it.

Stella's Starlight

Once upon a time, there was a very nice older woman named Stella. Actually, her real name was Estella, but she thought that was a bit too old fashioned, and so she changed it when she was younger. Stella had shiny silver hair, bright blue eyes and a very special secret. She had a light inside her body. It was not a light bulb, but an invisible glow that was magic. People could not see this glow, but they could sense it, and it made them feel warm and special. Children especially, were drawn to this light, like a moth, or a magnet.

Stella knew she was different, and she was glad about it because she was able to quickly understand the needs of people and how to communicate with them. She truly cared about individuals and animals; even plants and flowers.

Stella's dream was to bestow this "gift" of hers to her entire family. "What better time than this summer when we have our annual family reunion?" was her exciting idea.

The time soon came when all of her grandchildren were finished with school. The carefree summer, and the family reunion were about to take place again. This time it was planned by Jack, Stella's youngest son, and his sweet wife, Ann. They lived in Minneapolis and arranged for the family week to take place at Bug Bee resort, about three hours from their home. Stella paid for the lodgings and the four families took turns planning the meals, the outings and the entertainment. The siblings and cousins had an opportunity to bond again, check out the changes in the growing kids and re-establish family ties.

Sasha, the youngest, was no longer shy. Although she was only two and a half years old, Stella could feel the special light glowing from Sasha's fingertips. The little girl was able to fit the smallest part of a toy together, and accomplished the task with patience and fortitude.

Her five-year-old sister, Natalie, knew the lyrics to every song imaginable. And when the words escaped her memory, that was no problem whatsoever.... she simply made them up extemporaneously. Natalie's light was sparkling all over the place.

Coly, Jeff and Wan-Ling's youngest, initially seemed shy and quiet. But when challenged with a problem or if she became lost in the fun of a game, she literally burst out with shouts of excitement and joy. Her secrets were well hidden but her six-year-old thirst for knowledge and accomplishment were evident. Stella remembered back to last year's reunion, when she offered to read Coly a story. The little granddaughter silently listened attentively, and when asked if she recognized any of the letters, she replied, "Yes, all of them. Would you like me to read you the story Bubby?"

Stella was astounded, and allowed the eager light in Coly's eyes to surround them as the story was again unfolded without a flaw.

During the family's talent show, eleven-year-old Sarina elected to play a few selections on the piano. She performed beautifully and was quite reserved. Sarina holds rainbow glows within her that emerge as playful bolts of lightening. Her skills in art and color are reflections of her mother's talents, but her ability to mimic animals and foreign accents are her very own.

Sarina's cousin, Leaf, three months her senior, is also blessed with artistic and musical aptitudes. As a middle child, she is truly an "in-between," with special challenges. Leaf is seldom without a book in her hand, and is curious about many aspects of life. Her intelligence and kindly attitude shines through, as well as her inner strength and resolution. Her caring and leadership skills promise a future of meaningful contributions.

Forest is next on the ladder of grandkids. Stella tries to decide which glows more; his mischievous, knowing dark eyes, or his carefully coifed gelled black hair. She decides it is his self-confidence and sense of humor that make up the star on his tree. His fourteen-year-old heart loves all the girls in the world, and they, of course love him back. Forest not only possesses a light; he owns his own spotlight!

The first cousin who challenges Forest at chess and any intricate game or puzzle is Leaf's older brother, Wren. During his sixteen years, Wren has excelled in many areas. An accomplished violinist, singer, actor, linguist, and leader in scientific and political studies, he can beam into many vocations and make a success of it. A near clone of his father, Jeff, Wren eagerly addresses new encounters with a positive attitude. One needs sunglasses when around Wren.

Last, but never least, is Robin, sixteen and a half years old. Put her in water and she becomes a mermaid. But a strong one! She is on the high school swim team and surpasses many youngsters in soccer. Robin is extremely maternal and is a magnet to little tykes. Although she lights up inside, no glow can outshine her golden tresses. Her silken mane reflects lights like a mirror. It is something to behold.

Stella also reflects and muses over her discoveries. The grand kids already have the special starlight, plus they're all so darned good looking. Where did they get it from? Their parents, of course! And where did the parents get it from? Ahh, satisfaction. So Stella has her wish. And although, the once popular song, "Stella By Starlight" tickles her vanity, the theme that means more to her, is bound to perpetuate for a long time. This is a symphony that will illuminate her family tree for many years to come.

Princess Sarina and the Frog

Because she was the only child in the palace, princess Sarina learned to amuse herself with her surroundings. She took long walks in the nearby forest and befriended the small creatures that dwelled there. The trees seemed to be aware of her presence and would flutter their leaves as she strolled through the fragrant paths.

Sarina did not fear the insects. She marveled at their beautiful colors and graceful motion as they swooped through the foliage. The soft breeze played with her shiny chestnut hair as she stooped to breathe the sweet bouquet offered by delicate wild flowers. Sarina was content with her young life, although she missed the presence of a companion with whom she could discuss the books she loved, her secret longings, and her ambition to make a contribution to mankind.

The princess often thought about how she could help to eliminate wars and bring about a better appreciation for nature and all the wonders that too many people did not see. It pained her to realize how small and large animals were mistreated because she truly cared for all living things.

One day, after strolling through her beloved woods, she came upon a brook of clear water and crouched down to satisfy her thirst. The drink was cool and delicious but unknowingly Sarina swallowed a frog's egg that floated in the water. The incident did not seem to make any difference until Sarina began to feel a bit jumpy days later. Her chestnut hair took on a green glow, which was quite attractive. It was this new restlessness that made her fidgety and caused her to run through the forest as quickly as she could. There were times when she would literally leap from shrub to shrub, and it felt so exciting.

The royal parents were too busy managing the estate and the village to notice any change in their daughter. Sarina's inner

turbulence continued until one night, when she experienced a strange dream. She envisioned a pond with colorful floating flowers, and on one of the broad, shiny leaves sat the most charming frog she had ever seen. As Sarina blinked her eyes, the pond disappeared, but the attractive frog remained, sitting on her green satin pillow!

"Well hello there," exclaimed Sarina. "Where did you come from?"

"I sort of drifted out of your body dear princess" said the frog in a velvety voice.

"I never thought a frog could talk," said the surprised princess.

"And I never knew anyone who could understand me," was the reply.

At last, here was the companion that Sarina had yearned for. The frog was so compassionate and understanding. They spoke of many things and tried to solve the problems of the land. He was funny too and would perform many tricks that would cause the princess to laugh until her sides ached.

Months passed and the two friends grew closer and more precious to each other. One moonlit night, when the light sparkled on the smooth pond, Sarina found that her heart was overflowing with love for her dear friend. She gathered him up in her hands, drew him to her lips, and placed a warm kiss on his face. The leaves on the trees rustled loudly, and flowers swirled around them in a cloud. When the turbulence quieted down, there on a shiny green leaf, sat two blissful frogs. One was adorned with a tiny crown and she whispered, "What has happened?"

"You have broken the spell dear Sarina. It was destined that you join the world of nature's creatures and become my bride" said the velvety voice.

The wedding took place near the pond and was attended by all the friendly creatures that Sarina and her new mate loved. Not too long afterwards, they were blessed with twins, whom they named Robert and Ribbit.

They lived happily ever after.

My twelve-year-old granddaughter, Sarina, and I are pen pals. She is crazy about frogs and frog figures. She even has a frog "shrine" with candles around it. The worst part about it is that she makes a frog face and voice that I can't stand. My spurning of her character hurt her feelings, so I suggested a new tact where we would compose a story and take turns with the installments. I was to start it but when I got into it, I couldn't stop. My plan is to submit to her the first page and let her continue. When "ours" is completed, I will send her this draft that I present to you.

Romancing the Kitchen

Sliced bread in my parents' home? Never! My mother proclaimed that all the air that sliced bread was exposed to, sucked all the vitamins out of the wheat. No "Wonder" that people who ate that white, sliced stuff got sick so often. Picture this health-hearty woman with a large rye bread, positioned perpendicular to her chest, with a long, sharp knife, slicing straight towards her heart. We kids weren't concerned because all of our aunts did the same thing and they never missed dinner.

The kitchen was our home. That's where we ate, entertained, fed relatives, read the comics, did our homework and breathed in the luscious aromas that accompanied that night's dinner. We always ate together and waited for our father to join us. He would arrive home after a day at his used furniture store, grimy but not too tired to greet us with elated anticipation. The dialogue would be the same, but we loved it.

"So, did the teacher send you to the principal's office and put you back into kindergarten?" I would go along with the scenario and pretend to cry and act terribly ashamed of myself. "Yes, Poppa," I would whine, "And I got D's and F's on my report card!" "Woe is me," he would anguish, "That's the end of the world." As expected, but just as exciting, I would jump up and down and scream, "I fooled you, I got A's and got promoted!"

My father would then pick me up, make a little swing with his arms, and sing his own little ditty while wildly swinging me back and forth. This gave my mother a chance to fix his bath and lay out clean clothing for her Prince Charming. He would come to the dinner table, pink and shining and ready for a wonderful meal, prepared by his perpetual bride, Bella.

If especially good news could not wait during the daytime, my mother would allow me to phone him at the store, even though the call cost ten cents. He and I would go through the crying shame of it all and then burst forth with the wonderful report that would culminate with my sweet father's elated shouts and song. I never wondered then, what his customers thought of this unexpected entertainment, perhaps in the midst of a sale?

The warm environment of the kitchen never left us even though we often spent hot New York summers in the Catskill Mountains. My mother and other moms rubbed cut garlic cloves over the round crispy crust of fresh pumpernickel bread, slice it (again against the chest) and spread either sweet butter or chicken shmaltz (fat) that was adorned with crunchy fried onions. *Dee*licious! It was mandatory that the entire little community do the same, in order to remain on speaking terms without fainting.

Another fun activity in the mountains was gathering blueberries. They grew wild near our bungalows and would occupy the children for an afternoon. After they were rinsed in cold well water, the berries, not the kids, we were given our reward; a bowl of juicy berries topped with thick, sweet sour cream.

Noses got lots of exposure to a large variety of fragrances. Mostly favorable. There were a couple of instances that I remember that I never divulged to my hard working mother. Sometimes, at bedtime, I would urge my fatigued mom to spoon with me for a little while. When she agreed, she would cuddle my back in my bed "just for a few minutes." I remember quietly tying her apron strings to my pajamas so that she would remain longer. Her arms would encompass me as I moved her rough hands to my cheek. It was then that my nose

spoiled everything. Her dear chapped hands reeked of onions and garlic and I nearly tossed my cookies. Wrapping the blanket around her hands, I was finally able to sink into slumber land.

A frequent kitchen visitor was my elderly aunt; my grandfather's older sister. Her name was Tante Molka Tzerel. Molka translates to "queen." I recently figured out that my aunt must have been in her late sixties, but at that time, she seemed ancient, and had no teeth. She walked at least two miles to get to our house, and if anyone spotted her coming, we would run like mad to alert my mother so that she could prepare herself mentally and physically. My aunt's one-sided conversations would continue non-stop and we pitied my mother, who was very polite and always looked like she was listening. There were times when nature called and my aunt would follow my poor mother into the bathroom, sit herself down on the bathtub rim, and continue her gossip and medical complaints.

She had a particular ritual that absolutely fascinated me. After my mother made the usual glass of tea, accompanied with a crispy kaiser roll and sweet butter, my aunt would dip a chunk into the tea so that she could "gum" it down, and polish it off without missing a beat in her speech. It was afterwards that my childish eyes were glued to the tablecloth. Tante Molka Tzerel would methodically smash each crumb with her thumb. Her action seemed to match the emotion with which she told her stories, and most of them were accusations. When the crumbs were powdered to smithereens, she would brush them to the floor with her pinky and start on a fresh batch.

Before our guest would arrive, my mother forewarned us—actually threatened us—to be on our best behavior as the tante was more effective than a radio broadcaster in relating *everything* to *everybody*. Mama wouldn't even allow us to impersonate our relative lest, through some supernatural means, tante would know about our teasing.

My sisters and I usually had a few chores to do, but on Sunday, sweet Sunday, after breakfast, we would sprawl on the kitchen floor to read the comics. My mother often sang while she did her cooking, the dishes etc. and she was at peace with her kids happily enjoying the relaxed morning. One Sunday, my father entered the kitchen, and became very upset with the scene. Perhaps he felt guilty because he, and 99 percent of the husbands, then, never helped out with "woman's work." He grabbed a seltzer bottle and shpritzed us to get across the message that we should be helping our mother. It worked!

And so it went. The kitchen was our living room, our family room and it never lost its warm and magnetic charm.

Readers, My Jest

THE FOLLOWING STORIES ARE MY CONTRIBUTIONS TO A POPULAR MAGAZINE:

Humor in Uniform

"Corporal of the guard, corporal of the guard!"

Those insistent words pierced through the darkness of the cool morning air. My husband, sporting his new chevron on his sleeve, was performing his first stint of guard duty. The sharp call was at a distance, but Sam was quick to respond.

"Identify yourself!," he commanded. No answer. Yet, a few minutes later, the cry was repeated.

"Corporal of the guard, corporal of the guard!"

With an elevated heartbeat, Sam again demanded,

"Identify yourself!" Silence. Soon, his replacement arrived and sleepily declared, "If it wasn't for that damn rooster and his 'Cockle doodle doo', I would have been late."

While on bivouac duty in the desert, my husband was warned to be on the alert for snakes and other critters. He soon prepared his tent and retired for the night. Deep sleep was interrupted when he felt a cold weight across his chest. Grabbing the creature, he flung it as hard as he could. Lying at the foot of the tent opening, he realized that the cold "snake" was his arm that had fallen asleep.

Life in These United States

Mr. Johnson wearily sat down in a New York restaurant, and sighed to the waiter, "I don't need a menu. I've been on my feet all day and all I want is a bowl of chicken soup with dumplings, a smile, and a kind word." "Okay," said the waiter. In a few minutes, he returned with the soup, smiled and said, "Enjoy!" "Hold on," replied Mr. Johnson, "You forgot the kind word." The waiter then bent over and whispered, "Don't eat the dumplings."

Mrs. Bordon and Mrs. Doolittle were rocking in their chairs on the porch of a popular summer resort.

"Just look at that boy coming our way. Such a crooked mouth, and what weird eyes. Who would give anyone a silly haircut like that?" exclaimed Mrs. Doolittle

In a freezing voice, Mrs. Bordon replied, "You happen to be talking about my son."

"Don't take it that way," responded Mrs. Doolittle, "On him it's very becoming."

Cynthia and Rosalie met again at a school reunion. It had been several years since their last meeting.

"Darling, you look absolutely marvelous!" exclaimed Rosalie. "What do you do to look so good?"

"Shhh, I'll tell you a secret....I'm having an affair!"

"Wow. That's fantastic. Who's catering?"

During the Spring break at an out of state university, Gloria brought home her new fiancé to meet her parents. Dwayne was a theology student. Gloria's mother whispered to her husband, "Check the fellow out and make sure he's ready to take care of our daughter."

Mr. Stone invited Dwayne into the library and proceeded to ask him about the young mans' ability to provide for Gloria in the manner she was accustomed to.

"God will provide Sir." was the reply.

"What about vacations and trips?"

"God will provide Sir."

"And if children come along, what then?"

Same answer; "God will provide."

Mrs. Stone anxiously asked her husband what his opinion was of the boy. He said , "The bad news is, the boy is financially broke. The good news is, "He thinks I'm God !"



There once was a woman from Roseville,
Who loved to dine daily on road kill,
She found it nutritious,
And strangely delicious,
It saved her a bunch on her food bill!

Her Inaugural Visit to the Gynecologist

Our first daughter was a perfect first child. If she had only slept through the night during her initial three years, she would have been more than perfect. Laurisa made up for it, almost, by being cute, funny and a very rapid learner. One of her favorite places to visit at age three was the library. She loved to become one of the characters in the story and would amusingly act out scenes.

Jeannie Lou Highnote lived across the street, in Downey, California. Although she was four years older than Laurisa, Jeannie Lou attached herself to her little friend. Perhaps her degree of intelligence (it was mighty low) inspired her to admire and look up to her younger playmate. Laurisa was quick to recognize the many flaws in her buddy's grammar. And it was amusing to see our little squirt correct her good natured pal with, "Don't say ain't, say yes!"

School soon became another of Laurisa's passions. She excelled in her studies, had lots of friends and loved everything about her education at Rancho Santa Gertrudes Elementary School. In order for her to miss a day, there would have to be a world famine or at least a major earthquake.

One day, as my eight-year-old was leaving for school, (she walked the two blocks), I noticed a "John Wayne" gait about her. Her waddle reminded me of a cowboy who had just dismounted from his wide horse.

"What's wrong Laurisa? You're walking funny."

"I don't want to be late for school Mom. I'll tell you later," she answered. And off she lumbered Western style, with Jeannie Lou catching up, physically, not mentally.

Six hours later, when my cowgirl arrived home, it looked like her horse had grown wider.

"Laurisa, please tell me what's troubling you," I implored.

"It's nothing Mom—my vulva hurts," she explained, always using the correct terminology.

"Follow Dr. Mom to your bedroom and we'll take a look," instructed the good "doctor."

Glaring me in the face was an extremely large, angry boil. I doubted that the cowgirl would be able to straddle the horse, which by tomorrow would have gained fifty pounds. To what kind of a doctor does one take an eight year old with trouble in the lower extremities?

By that time, our family had grown to five, with the youngest still nursing. My husband Sam offered to take time off from work and escort our daughter to the gynecologist.

Laurisa was very excited about her new adventure although she proposed to crawl to school instead. We all insisted that she get the medical attention she required and that was that! We put a soft cushion on the passenger side of the car, (kids could ride in the front then) and Laurisa and Sam went on their way to the OBGYN.

In the waiting room, Sam cuddled close to his daughter to comfort her but was not prepared for the reception he got from the other anticipative patients, most of whom were very pregnant. They gave him filthy looks, shook their heads while "tsk, tsking" and glanced sympathetically at the abused child clinging to her father, the molester.

The real doctor prescribed a salve and recommended frequent zits baths. (That was some zit!) If the boil refused to open and drain, it would have to be lanced. The word alone made Laurisa cringe and she vowed to soak and soak. She dramatically gave the

details, especially the new addition to her vocabulary, to Jeannie Lou, who had to learn how to spell "lance" and correctly use it in three different sentences.

Fortunately, the abscess responded to all the hot water. That was a relief because Laurisa's homework kept falling into the tub. John Wayne's walk reverted to a skip and a jump, and after a few years, the visit to the gynecologist paid off again. Laurisa became a nurse practitioner and a mid-wife. And no, Jeannie Lou Highnote was not her first patient.

United Airlines: It's Time to Fly (or Cry?)

In addition to our annual family reunion, I try to visit each one of my far-flung children and their families as frequently as possible. This year, it was time to check out my oldest son, Jeff, his wife, Wan-Ling and their two daughters who were on spring break. Their first child, Wren, was attending Swarthmore College in Pennsylvania. Their home is in Richmond, Virginia. As Wan-Ling's birthday occurred during my stay, and as she and Jeff would be working at Virginia University, my granddaughters, Leaf and Coly, and I planned a surprise dinner and party when they arrived home on April 13th.

Before I go into the fun part, I need to explain the title of my essay. Reservations were in place two months before the trip. I scheduled an early departure so that I could be picked up in Richmond at a reasonable hour. My alarm clock was set for 2 a.m. as Super Shuttle was picking me up at 3:30 a.m.. Everything went well and I boarded the 6 a.m. flight with the plan to grab a pillow and enjoy my window seat. It's easy for me to snooze with the pillow and window area to lean on. As passengers filled the plane, my seatmates were a little five-year-old girl, and on the aisle, the mother, carrying her one-year-old daughter. They all seemed to have nice dispositions, and I really like kids so all was fine…for a while.

Unfortunately, I wore my favorite crystal pendant, which reflects rainbows of colors. After she dismissed her shyness, the baby stepped on her big sister's lap and tried to suck my jewelry. The mother laughingly called the baby back to her lap. The five year old put on her earphones and began to dance wildly in her seat to rap music. She flung her arms and kicked up, down and out. And we had not taken off yet! The delay not only seemed long, it *was* long. After an hour of not moving, the pilot announced that due to stormy weather

in Chicago, the connecting flight, we needed to wait for clearance. I used every Lamaze method I could think of to try to doze off, but none of them worked too well.

Two more hours went by in slow motion, and the darling little girls were just getting revved up. If the plane had not been packed full, I could have requested another seat. Toys, books and backpacks covered the floor while Momma conversed with her friend across the aisle. I desperately willed myself not to think of bladders, even though drinks were offered. Amanda, who already was calling me Grandma, ordered an orange juice. (You know what's coming!) She exclaimed, "See, I can drink it from a straw, all by myself", as she proudly flung it right onto my lap. I could feel the cold liquid soak my velvet pants, and my underwear. Bladder thoughts immediately entered my mind, and this time, could not be ignored. I needed to step across four feet of stuff and hope that the line at the end of the plane would not be too long.

There was only one person in front of me and she looked suspiciously at my wet pants. Couldn't she smell the orange juice? She finally exited the facility, and I squeezed into the tiny "closet". Trying to find a spot for my purse, I backed into position and gratefully began to "bless" the commode. The plane jerked, and BANG! The lid fell down. It was impossible to discontinue the blessing and I admit to using two four letter words. My pants now would have satisfied the smirk on the face of the woman who preceded me. Twenty paper towels later, with sweat on my brow, and very negative thoughts, I emerged from the damp throne and returned to my seat.

The pilot's notice informed us that the wait to take off would end pretty soon. Pretty soon was another four hours, and my ankles were

beginning to swell. When we finally arrived in Chicago, and waited another two hours for a parking spot, I learned that my connecting flight had been cancelled.

The departure chart listed another flight to Richmond in one hour. It was located in the furthest possible area! I was close to tears by then but kept plodding on with wet pants yet. A young attendant with a wheel chair asked if I was OK. I replied, "No," and thankfully sank into his chair. He whisked me across the airport, got me to the right gate on time, and the windy ride helped to dry my pants. Luckily, I got the last seat available, and arrived in Richmond a few hours behind schedule.

It was great to be greeted by happy faces, although one of my suitcases was missing and would be delivered the following afternoon. Of course, that was the suitcase with my clothing, underwear etc.

The actual visit was delightful and the dinner/party was fun for all. When I relayed my adventure with United Airlines, my son said, "See how lucky you are? You have a readymade essay waiting to be written." He was right, only next time I want to fly dry.

Murphy's Law

Besides our parents, or a favorite relative, it is often a special teacher who makes a lasting impression on our lives. Mr. William Murphy, my math and science teacher, gets my vote for making a big change in my confidence and willingness to take charge.

The fifth grade was my turning point and it was because of this Irish mentor who always had a twinkle in his extraordinarily blue eyes. Mr. Murphy also sported a thick, brush mustache, animated black eyebrows and a delightful sense of humor. His amorous glances at our music teacher, Miss Jennings, caused her to turn beet red when he entered our room during class. She was the slender, demure June Allyson type (before the need for Depends) and owned the sweetest, purest soprano voice.

I vividly recall an occasion, during one of her songs, when Mr. Murphy opened the door and beamed a mischievous look in her direction. Her high C was not part of the music but it was a notable note. Miss Jennings was delighted when we requested a specific song, but little did she know why. She had a large repertoire of Irish songs and the one we naughtily requested most was a sailor song, "The Captain's Gig." Poor Miss Jennings had no idea that, at that time, many of the students referred to "breast" as "gig" or "giggy," depending on the size. At ten or eleven years of age, that was a huge topic of interest.

P.S. 233, a four-story brick building, accommodated a mix of ethnic groups of children from kindergarten through the eighth grade. Every Friday, all classes were seated in the assembly room for our weekly encounter. It always began with a biblical reading by our principal, from the New Testament, which made the Jewish kids edgy. It was then, in front of all of those people, that Mr. Murphy

would announce, "Estelle Siegel will now explain the importance of supporting the American Red Cross." This was a topic we had discussed in Home Room that morning, but never in a million years did I expect to be called upon to announce it on the stage of the auditorium. I obediently walked to the center of the stage, looked into Mr. Murphy's twinkling eyes, and did the best I could. I paid strict attention to all future topics as he repeated this request several times thereafter.

Another challenge that I recall was the task of delivering a note to Miss Jennings. All I was told was that she was on the fourth floor. I trudged up the stairs and glanced around at the unfamiliar rooms. I looked at all the names posted outside the doors, but could not find hers. Twenty minutes later, I explained my frustration to Mr. M., expecting sympathy. Instead, the blue eyes turned to flashing green and he admonished, "When you are given an assignment, you must complete it. Go find her, deliver the message, and don't return until you do!"

The stairs seemed steeper this time, but I climbed them while I tried to invent a procedure to locate this teacher. Luckily, when I "landed", I saw another member of the faculty who looked familiar. I inquired where Miss Jennings might be and she pointed to the Teachers' Rest Room. Happily, my mission would soon be accomplished, but I saw that innocent Miss Jennings was smoking! When I handed her the note from Mr. Murphy, all the other instructors broke into laughter while the recipient turned crimson.

There was one other time when Miss Jennings' face flared a deeper red. It wasn't when she opened the class's Christmas gift to her. Our mothers had chipped in to buy her a practical gift which she adored…a pair of warm "woolies" (knee length underwear). Her accelerated coloration occurred after the holidays when she returned and announced that she had a new name, Mrs. Murphy. To celebrate, she distributed candy to each of us and said she would be happy to entertain us with some songs. Guess which one we enthusiastically requested? You're right!

Two Deadly Sins

That's right; I, the pure and righteous Estelle Marilyn El-Hai, whose name means, "The Living Goddess," went off the beaten track, and committed not one, but two "sins." I put that in quotes because I really, really don't believe they were evil sins, but they were something I had never done before in my whole glorified life. And they did make me feel a little strange and watchful.

It happened last Monday night, on the eve of Passover. I had made a terrific seder, a traditional Passover dinner, for some relatives the night before. Although it was not actually the beginning of the holiday yet, it was the only day that my family could get here without worrying about missing work or school. So we bent it like Beckham. That has nothing to do with the sin part because the dinner was delicious and the ceremony went very well.

The questionable part was the timing and the situation. I had dinner at the Lodge on the eve of an important holiday, ate food that was absolutely not sanctioned by observant Jewish people, and I did this with a *married man*—Don't be shocked; it was extremely platonic. His wife was away on a two-week trip (I actually like her more than I do her husband), and he said he was lonely. Nice line? Well, I checked with another friend who knew him for many years, who said that she went with him, with her husband's blessing, to Thunder Valley because he was forlorn and needed cheering up. So why didn't he go on the wonderful trip with his wife, I inquired? Answer: His health condition did not permit it.

Mentally, I felt ok with my decision to share dinner with him, although I insisted on dutch treat to make sure there would be no misinterpretations. The one thing I was concerned about was not meeting any members of the Jewish Fellowship because that would

make me uncomfortable. They probably would be uneasy as well, so I thought.

As soon as I ordered my drink, the first incident occurred. I was explaining to the waitress how to make an iced coffee (she had never heard of this drink, so popular on the east coast), when the first Jewish couple appeared. We waved hello across the room, and smiled weakly. I told my Catholic companion, that I hoped there would not be another friend of the Hebrew persuasion in the restaurant. Three other couples of the aforesaid persuasion, joyfully visited our table and asked me how I liked my dinner, and who was my friend? One of them, in an overly friendly way, sat down at our table and made some conversation, and inquiries.

My dinner comrade seemed amused when they left and confessed that his first wife was Jewish, and thought the whole thing was quite comical. I expect that the evening's events will be written up in the Courier and the Hebrew National Enquirer.

Luckily, we had to leave after two hours because my friend couldn't, or shouldn't, drive when it's dark. The wife in question is now home from her Asian trip and will re-hash the events with me at our coming Red Hat luncheon. I was told that I performed a favor for a nice man in need. I sent him home with some matzo to share with my friend, his wife.

I don't think I was a sinner, do you?

Kin Is In

A friend (?) suggested to the Genealogy Club in Sun City that I be the guest speaker at one of their monthly meetings. This will really be a challenge for me, or a big surprise for the group, as I am not a very methodical person, who enjoys pondering over dates and intricate matters. I love action! I love people! I love love !! But best of all, I do love family.

Therefore, the Genealogy members will not get their usual expert on how to locate dates of arrivals in Ellis Island, or how to pinpoint Mormon Temples and their endless lists of immigrants (and closet skeletons). The coordinator asked me to bring instructions or techniques in gathering data. I will share with them the purpose of my memoirs and how they fly into my mind. Shall I disclose how I quietly remain in bed at 5 A.M. and mentally travel back to my childhood, or young motherhood, and conjure up a strategy as to a clever, funny, and truthful way of presenting it? It would have been priceless if my grandparents and parents were able to do the same thing. Wouldn't you have found their memoirs to be precious to you? (Your family; not mine.) By 6 A.M., I am at my computer, and my thoughts simply flow out.

If I come to an impasse, I put my masterpiece into "memory" and give it a rest. My recall is vivid and quite accurate. The family is familiar with what I'm doing and cheer me onward. Although I frequently share my short stories with them, one day they will get the whole kit and caboodle.

My dear mother Bella should have been a writer, but she could tell wonderful stories about her youth. She was born in Russia; Krastnostov, Valinsky Gabernia. It's quite impressive when I verbalize it with rolling R's. When she was just eighteen, she came to the United States with her girlfriend, Deena, mostly to escape a homely cousin to whom she was betrothed. She quickly began working as a seamstress, for her uncle in Hartford, Connecticut. One weekend, she and her friend decided to see the "City," Brooklyn, New York. It was a warm summer day and many of the residents sat on their stoops drinking lemonade. As Bella strolled by, the mother of a family group glanced admiringly at her and whispered in Yiddish, "Ah zeesa puhnum!," which means "a sweet face." Bella acknowledged the compliment with, "Ah shayna deinkach." (A very nice thank you.) The family was startled that she understood. Her bright blue eyes and cute little nose indicated to them that she was a shicksa (gentile).

Yiddish was a language of glue because most Jews knew this universal tongue. My father came from Rumania and could speak English, Rumanian and Yiddish. As he was the oldest child of the Siegel clan, and the darling of the family, he picked up the reins and continued the conversation with the pretty stranger. She and her friend were invited to the public pool the next weekend where handsome Jack could show off his great physique. He was able to ripple his pectorals, one at a time if he chose. Beautiful Bella was smitten and they were wed six months later.

The betrothed cousin arrived a few weeks late, but stayed in the family and became Uncle Harry. When I was old enough to understand the story, I was so glad that Uncle Harry did not become my father. Harry and his future wife, Bessie, loved to eat raw onions and herring. They also laughed a great deal so it was very painful to be near them.

The war broke out at that time so New York became the permanent home for the Russian immigrants. Besides, although my

mother missed her family very much, she also told frightening stories of the Cossack soldiers and how they bullied and caused havoc in the Jewish villages; especially when they were drunk.

My mother was also a deceiving diplomat. She had four children and whenever we visited her, after we were grown, our picture would be displayed on the piano. No matter which of her offspring called on her, the proper photograph appeared in the frame. Of course, there were four pictures stacked in that frame, so it was effortless to quickly produce the correct one. She probably had a spare frame if two of us appeared at the same time. Mother Bella was a mild but determined stage door mom. We started out entertaining visiting relatives. When she heard on the radio that auditions were being held for talented children, we were there. My middle sister and I took tap dance, acrobatic and piano lessons. Radio music filled our house and we were encouraged to dance with ribbons and scarves flowing. She sat with us when we did our homework, so that she could learn to speak more eloquently.

Bella was also a leader, and became president of Hadassah and active in the PTA. She organized a kitty so that my third grade teacher would get a nice Christmas present from the class. Being very practical, and considering the weather, the grateful teacher received a pair of long "woolies," that warmed the cockles of her "heart."

My father had the most beautiful handwriting I had ever seen, and I was tremendously proud to have him sign my report card. His signature could have adorned the Declaration of Independence, with its' flourishes and curlicues. He was not as intellectual as Bella but he had a heart of gold, which the relatives loved to spend. He worked hard and established a fine used furniture store in Brownsville. The

community loved him and he became financially successful as soon as my mother took charge of the income.

Now, these are the kind of stories I could relate at the genealogy meeting. It might encourage a few people to expand the way they think of their families without, hopefully, destroying the club.

Dates are great when remembering kin,
But mem'ries are best; they live within.

Here She Comes ... Mrs. America!

As I approached Mar Vista Market in West Los Angeles that lovely spring day in 1962, I noticed a large crowd gathering in the parking lot. My breath quickened as I envisioned an outdoor sale of bargains. Or, I thought with accelerated excitement, it might be a contest. I squiggled closer to the action and saw a familiar man speaking on a microphone. Although, I couldn't recall his name, and still can't, I had seen him on television programs.

Mr. X was explaining that they were planning to conduct a Mrs. America contest and selected residents, of the female persuasion, would have a chance to participate, first in the Mrs. California competition, and later in the national pageant.

"Is it a bathing suit contest?" a plump lady inquired.

"No ma'am," answered suave Mr. X. He was getting handsomer by the minute. "This is a competition for married women, who like to cook, serve in community affairs, have hobbies and poise. There will be many prizes for the winners."

"But what does she have to wear?" asked Mrs. Zoftig (chubby) as she munched on a candy bar.

"There is one evening gown event, but most of the time it's casual attire."

"So, why are you here?" a fairly attractive, dark at the roots, blonde queried.

"I'm here to interview a few women who might want to join the fun." said Mr. Gorgeous.

Several women screamed and jumped with joy, and others, including my eager self, raised our hands straight up. He beckoned to me and four or five others, and one at a time, proceeded to ask questions. I noticed that an official looking gentleman nearby was taking notes so when my turn came, my size ten posture was never better. Most of the questions were about my interests, number of children, type of cooking I enjoy (the Greek recipes made a good impression) and if I revel in decorating my home.

At the conclusion, he said that the elected participants would be notified. I was so exalted that I almost forgot to shop for dinner. There was much discussion around the dinner table about my experience.

In two days, I received a phone call from the television studio saying that they would like me to represent Mrs. Studio City, as there was already someone representing Mar Vista.

"I love Studio City," I exclaimed, although I had never been there.

The plan was to attend an orientation at the Ambassador Hotel; very classy indeed. We then had two weeks to prepare for the final competition, which would include three days of special activities, including a parade the evening gown event and a live interview.

My youngest son had just entered first grade so I had a little time for the new project. My wardrobe was not Mrs. America material so I made a beeline to Penny's. Happily, my sister-in-law was the head of alterations at the local May Company. Sweetie pie Rae, was very glad to lend her expertise, and she made the clothing fit like a velvet glove.

Preparing a main dish was the first event. All of the ingredients were provided for, with a portion of the extravagant kitchen of the Ambassador Hotel to use as we wished. They got the grape leaves that I requested, and everything else that went into my dolmades recipe. It came out scrumptious, and my Greek mother-in-law would have proudly spit three times in my direction.

Making festive centerpieces was the next challenge and we were provided with a budget to get our own materials. I went to a party shop and bought sparkly fronds and other fun things. It turned out great and I duplicated twelve more two years later when we planned my older son's bar-mitzvah reception.

We had a parade the next day, in vintage cars. This event could be seen on television, so we were advised to wear pretty hats and wave our gloved hands a great deal. Many of my neighbors saw that show and reported to me the next day, how excited they were to recognize me.

Evening gowns and televised interviews came the following day, and my sis-in-law, Rae was more nervous than I was. That beautiful Alice-blue gown was practically sewn on me, and by necessity, my height increased an extra inch. We knew that our hobbies and interests would be discussed, and as the prime barber in the family, I figured out that I had saved $1,400 by clipping the tresses of my husband and four kids. My artwork and weird healthy recipes brought some laughter. I felt confident while Ralph Edwards, the master of ceremonies talked with me, and could hardly wait for the four finalists to be declared.

The third runner up eludes me but the second runner up was the tall, attractive African American wife of a famous basketball player from UCLA. My name was called next as the first runner up, with the title of Mrs. California going to an OK looking woman who had eight children. I know it sounds like sour grapes because it was.

All in all, it was a memorable event that will stay with me for a long time. My kids were pseudo celebrities for a while. Now, when I hear that song, "Here She Comes, Miss America," I realize the tension and exhilaration (and disappointment) that goes into it. The big main difference is that today, they all have plastic surgery, and you know where!!

Bridge over the Liver and Thigh

"I'm so aggravated, I could spit," growled Ike. "All those great deals at Costco, and I can't touch them. One club."

"So why do you go already, to be tormented and frustrated? One diamond." said Hannah, cautiously counting her points.

"Listen carefully Ike," counseled his partner, Gertrude, "*two* hearts... you're listening? And why get upset about the bargains, which are no bargains if you can't use all that stuff."

"You can save lots of moolah if you have a place to store the goods. Two spades." offered Max.

Ike reviewed his cards and said excitedly, "Gerty, I'm talking to you... three no trump! Got it? Is there a solution to this Costco thing? I feel like I'm losing money and a great opportunity by not buying there."

Hannah reviewed her cards again, shrugged her shoulders and said, "I pass. But I have an idea if the rest of you are open-minded. We could all go together, on Ike's membership card, choose the best buys, and split it up."

Gertrude's face flushed pink as she responded with, "Four no trump. And I like Hannah's idea about sharing the bill and the merchandise. Besides, their all beef hot dogs would make a delicious lunch and we could make a day of it."

Max frowned and muttered, "Pass."

The friends had been meeting for a weekly bridge game for almost twelve years and looked forward to a change of pace activity by planning the excursion to Costco. The following week, they readied themselves for the new adventure, equipped with comfortable walking shoes and calculators. Ike offered to drive but was politely turned down because he, after all, paid for the membership, and shouldn't have to take care of the gas as well.

They arrived as the doors opened and immediately headed for the free coffee and muffins.

"Already we've gained benefits," grinned Gerty.

"You'd better believe it." agreed Ike as he eyed Gerty's burgeoning figure. "Let's go up and down the aisles and save the food items for last. We don't want them to melt or spoil or anything."

"I'd like to check out the auto section. There are a few things I need." said Max.

"Oh pooh," lamented Hannah. "That's guy stuff. Go with Ike if you want to spend time with those macho things. Gerty, do you want to see what they have in ladies clothing? I could use a nice purse."

After an hour and no purchases, the group reconnoitered and decided it was time for lunch.

"Those purses were high quality," remarked Hannah as she dabbed some relish from her chin, "But I think I can get a better deal at Ross's especially if I go on Tuesdays, seniors' discount day.

"You're giving yourself away," smiled Max. "I never thought I was playing bridge with a silver fox."

The group finally agreed it was time to visit the food section.

"I've been requested to make my famous chopped liver dish for the Sunshine Committee's pot luck luncheon. What gorgeous chicken livers they have here, but you hafta buy ten pounds of it! Two and a half pounds would be perfect. What do you say pals?" queried Hannah.

"Personally, I always use baby beef liver and mine comes out the best in the world; better than my own mother's," declared Gertrude.

"I hate all kinds of liver," asserted Ike.

"I'm nauseous," admitted Max.

There still remained chicken parts of every description.

"Just look at this lovely chicken. All these plump thighs; such high quality. We can surely split this large tray full," said Gertrude hopefully.

"How about if we make it drumsticks? I'd go for that." offered Ike.

"I love the wings. All those bones fill the meat with lots of calcium and that's very important at our age. What do you like Max?" asked Hannah.

"I'm a breast man myself!," smirked Max.

They exited the area with no liver, no chicken, no nothing! As they left Costco, there was a large basket where customers could write their names and addresses, drop it in the hope chest and win valuable prizes.

The mission had been a failure, but the friends met, as usual, for their bridge game. As the cards were distributed, Max said, "Guess what I won from Costco?"

"You won a prize?," exclaimed Hannah.

"Yeah, I won a free membership to Costco," griped Max.

"So when are we going?," asked Gertrude.

Max simply said, "I pass!"

Bella, the Diplomat (or Fabricator?)

Growing up, I considered my mother to be above reproach. She was a nurturer, playful, beautiful, high-spirited and above all, truthful. Each one of her four children (I was the youngest) secretly knew that she/he was her favorite. I admired the humorous, robust Bella Siegel and believed all that she told me.

Sophie Grossman was a blonde, curly haired schoolmate in my second grade class. We had fun together and exchanged secrets. Once, Sophie confided that she knew where babies came from and I was proud to admit that my mother explained that to me recently. We were shocked to learn that our stories did not match and began to argue about it. There was only one logical solution; when school was out, we would walk to my home and ask my all-knowing mother.

After the usual hot cocoa and cookie, I asked my mother to give us the correct information so that I could accept Sophie's apology.

"Mama," I inquired, "You told me that a stork brings the new babies and Sophie says that a seed is planted in the mother to make the baby grow. Who's right, me or Sophie?"

As my mother calmly stirred her cup of Postum, she replied, "You are both right. Sometimes the stork brings the baby, but when he is too tired to carry it, he plants a seed in the mother and it grows into a new baby."

When I was a little older, I worried about the stork's very pointy beak and hoped that he wouldn't be too tired when it was time for him to bring me my baby. Nevertheless, Sophie and I remained friends but she never challenged me again.

My lovely mama had no belly button. She used to physically help my father in their used furniture store. When there was no other man around to assist my father in moving a heavy piece of household goods, my mother would help him lift very hefty items, including

a piano. She began to be troubled with pains in her abdomen and finally submitted to a hernia operation. In those days, the doctors made a huge vertical incision down the center of her belly. When the repairs were performed, the belly button disappeared.

Sophie, and several of my other pals did not believe me when I boasted that my mother didn't have, or need a belly button. Once again, we marched to my house after school so that I could prove what a cool mom I had. We didn't get the cocoa and cookie this time, but my good-natured parent allowed my buddies to check her out. No, she did not lift her housedress to reveal her missing orifice, but she allowed the curious kids to gently run their fingers down the center of her celebrity tummy. They really admired the fact that there was no indentation and could hardly wait to run home and tell their families and neighbors. I was a real hero that day.

The reason I titled my mother a diplomat is because she liked to make everyone feel special. This in turn, most likely made her feel special too. Whenever, as an adult, I visited her home, I was impressed that she always had a framed photograph of me displayed in the living room. My sister Bunny mentioned one day that our mother was so thoughtful to always have her (my sister's) photograph exhibited whenever she dropped in. My curiosity got the better of me, and during a subsequent visit, I discreetly picked up my framed picture and noticed a small bulge on the back of the frame. You guessed it. There were three other photos of my siblings neatly stacked and ready for a quick change. Somehow, when several of us were there at the same time, the suspect photo was nowhere to be found.

Mama Bella was an excellent cook and everything she made was very tasty. For several reasons, economical and emotional, she liked for us to finish everything in the plate. She would stand by and watch

as we devoured our dinner and would plop another spoonful onto our platters as soon as we were almost done. I was shocked to hear myself paraphrase her words when my children were growing up. No it wasn't "Millions of children all over the world are starving, so be sure to eat all your food." I never got the logic in that anyway. But I repeated her words, "All the good vitamins are at the bottom so be sure to finish up everything." Luckily, we were all active and had fine metabolisms and did not turn into blimps.

Although we were raised in a Jewish home, Christmas was a joyous time of the year and we always had fun during that season. We hung stockings on the kitchen chairs, not really expecting anything, but sort of hoping. My mom would fill her daughters' stockings with nuts, candies, barrettes, tangerines etc. My brother, who was the apple of her eye, got onions, garlic, banana peels and peanut shells.

Before school ended for the winter holidays, my mother took up a collection from the other mothers of my classmates and we proudly presented our teacher with a beautifully wrapped Christmas gift. With glistening eyes and a flushed face, our teacher, Miss Mabel Jennings, nervously opened her holiday present. She was really overcome with gratitude when she held up and admired a warm pair of woolies. For those of you who are not acquainted with that item, woolies are cozy, knitted underwear, which reach the tops of the knees. My mother told the others that she wished she had also brought the poor thing a jar of chicken soup.

I suppose I have inherited this diplomacy or fabricator gene, because I so love to make people happy, and I confess that I sometimes exaggerate or "decorate" a wee bit. But that's what art is, right? And beauty and kindness are so good for the soul. Besides, a little chicken soup and embellishment would nourish the bodies and spirits of all those perpetually starving children.

Pick or Sweet?

Nine-year-old Coly really, really loved school and could hardly wait for the new semester to begin. All three of her favorite friends were in her class and they were thinking of forming a club, but they had to originate a name and the purpose of meeting once a week.

Little did they realize that Miss Jennings, their current instructor, was going to provide the answers to both issues. She was a most likeable person, with a friendly smile and a mischievous twinkle in her eyes. On the first day of school, she passed out yellow sheets of paper to each student and said that she was going to give them an important assignment and the yellow paper was for listing ideas.

As Miss Jennings leaned on her desk, she looked into the eager eyes of her students, smiled, and declared, "You're going to love this assignment, because it's going to bring out the best in you. If you like, you may work in a group, or alone. The name of the project is "Make a Difference."

Coly quickly glanced at her friends, Reed, Ellie and Elizabeth, and they each nodded in agreement that this would be a group effort. Miss Jennings straightened her navy blue suit and said, "Because this assignment is so important, you may have two months to complete your report. It will be due before the Thanksgiving Day break."

During the lunch hour, the three friends all spoke at once, bubbling over with their ideas. Coly had a great thought, "How about naming our club, 'Make a Difference' and coming up with suggestions at our first meeting? You can come to my house and meet my two African grey parrots. They might have some important input." she giggled.

The following Saturday afternoon at one o'clock, Coly's friends arrived. There was a pitcher of apple juice and cookies on the table with a triangular paper napkin at each girl's place.

"Wow, this looks like a party!" exclaimed Reed, who loved goodies.

"Think of it as brain food, so we can get our work done." replied Coly. Pointing to the parrots, she introduced them." The larger one is Maize and the other one is Elwood."

"How nice that they can keep each other company and not be lonely," mentioned Ellie.

"Actually," said Coly, "The birds gave me a good idea of what our project can be."

Elizabeth was impressed. "You mean they told you what we should do?"

"No, you kook, I got the idea watching them and thinking about my grandmother, Bubby." Coly replied. "She lives in Sun City, where seniors live. There are no kids except on visits, and some of those people might get lonely."

"Don't kids go to Sun City for Halloween? Trick or treaters might cheer them up!" offered Elizabeth, as she polished off her fourth cookie. "And if we go there, we'll get lots of candy."

"That's partly a good idea Elizabeth," answered Coly, "But Bubby said that kids don't go to that area and the residents don't expect them to come, so they don't prepare anything."

Ellie raised her hand as if she were in school. "I've got it!," she shouted. "A week before Halloween, we could hand out flyers to the people in Sun City, and say they will be given a choice...to pick a favor that we offer them, or give us candy, whichever they want. We could call it, "Pick or Sweet."

The girls clapped their hands and the birds loudly whistled their approval. "That would really make a difference with them," laughed Coly. "We would add a little fun to their lives and they would get to be

with nice kids, like us. But what if they picked a favor? What kind of services could we offer?"

"Oh, we could mail letters for them, pick some weeds, or tell them a story." offered Reed. Then she pouted, "But if they choose a favor, we won't get candy."

Coly reminded her pals that this was to make a difference for others, so they got busy designing the flyer, with a large headline, PICK OR SWEET FOR HALLOWEEN. They decided to leave them at forty homes, ten for each of the girls. With their parents permission, and a couple of moms to accompany them, the colorful flyers were distributed after school, a week before Halloween.

The girls decided to dress as flowers, to sort of offer a "bouquet" to each resident. They each carried a bag in case they were given sweets. To calm themselves, they approached Bubby's house first, rang the doorbell, and when the door opened, said in unison, "Pick or sweet!"

"Well! What a nice surprise!," exclaimed Coly's grandmother. "Don't you all look beautiful."

"Which do you want Bubby?" said Coly. "Pick a favor for us to do, or donate a sweet?"

"I'll strike a deal with you. The wind blew lots of leaves on my driveway. If you sweep them up, you'll all get treats too." The clever grandmother gave the girls two brooms, and in five minutes the driveway was clean. "Good job," said Bubby. "I baked some oatmeal raisin cookies for all of you." Bubby was a health freak but most of her stuff was pretty good.

The happy club members thanked the grandmother and went on their way. Most of the other residents were prepared with goodies,

but a few of them were very pleased with the simple chores the girls did, and gave them sweets also.

They exited Sun City with full bags and when they got back to Coly's house, she had another brainstorm. "Let's make a big difference and share this loot with others." Elizabeth's father, who accompanied them, suggested that they take half of what was collected to Loaves and Fishes. The homeless people would appreciate a Halloween treat.

All the girls were surprised that they were happy to give away much of what they had accumulated, and the whole experience made them glow with pride and satisfaction. Miss Jennings was right; this event that they "picked," brought out the "sweetness" in each of them.

They each received an "A+" on their reports.

The Bubbly Duck

Mrs. Dubovsky smoothed the starched, flowery housedress over her ample bosom and lifted the window that faced her neighbor's home across the alley.

"Yoo hoo, Mrs. Siegel," she shrieked in a Molly Goldberg fashion. My mother responded by wiping her perpetually busy hands on her apron and slid up her window. "What is it Mrs. Dubovsky?" she inquired.

"So I heard that Estelle is going to take piano lessons from a regular teacher. When will she start, and how much will it cost you?"

"I just this minute called Miss Gershwin. How did you hear about it so fast?" said my mother incredulously.

Mrs. Du, as we referred to her somewhat affectionately, giggled and confessed, "Your bedroom window was open a little bit. So how much will you pay?"

"She's asking fifty cents for the hour, but before you tell me that's too much, she promises to have my Estelle play in a recital in six months!"

"My Shayndie is almost ten, six months older than your daughter and hates the idea of lessons. How will you make Estelle practice?"

"She wants to do it very badly and promises to practice every day. Enough Mrs. Dubovsky, my blintzes are calling me."

Miss Gershwin arrived the next day at 5 P.M. I learned later that her real name was Miss Gershowitz, but Gershwin had a tremendous impact on music-loving families. She was tall and extremely thin. Her nostrils dilated as she inhaled the delicious chicken soup aroma that permeated the rooms. My mother immediately offered her a glass of tea, which was accepted with gratitude. As extreme slenderness was a pain in the heart of a good Jewish mother, my instructor was also given a thick chunk of rye bread with lots of sweet butter. This was demolished in record time. I then sat next to my new acquaintance on

the shiny piano bench, and Miss Gershwin showed me my first book and explained the notes on the keyboard. In the book, she wrote and identified every note, and showed me how to curl my fingers and lift my wrists. By the end of the hour, I played a simple nursery rhyme with one uplifted hand, and felt extremely proud. Miss Gershwin then glued a gold star in the back of the book and said, "If you practice every day, you will learn a new song each week. When you do a good job, like you did today, you will get a gold star. When you earn ten gold stars, I will bring you a surprise."

I was so excited and my family loved to hear me practice. I memorized the songs because it was tedious to continuously refer to the penciled in notes. Soon there were ten shiny gold stars in my book.

Miss Gershwin wiped the last crumb of buttered rye bread from her slender face and gave me a wrapped package. Inside was a little Donald Duck that smelled wonderful. It was soap that bubbled and floated in the bathtub. What a wonderful present!

The pieces became classical and before long, I was playing, "To a Wild Rose" and "March Militaire" It was necessary for me to memorize everything because I hadn't been taught to read the notes.

One day, my piano teacher gave my mother a program to the recital I would participate in. There was my name and the two selections I would play printed in beautiful letters on the roster. This glorious event would take place in a special building in down town Brooklyn. We invited the neighbors, several friends and many relatives. My mother bought me a new navy blue, silky dress with black patent leather shoes. I convinced her to put on taps after the recital because dancing and acrobatics were next on the agenda.

Although I remember that my hands were sweaty and slid on the Steinway note keys, I didn't make any mistakes and it was a complete success. We all had a sumptuous Chinese dinner afterwards.

My piano career continued for several years and I accumulated many gold stars and interesting gifts from my teacher, who never seemed to put on a pound. My mother was puzzled and felt challenged. She even added honey to the buttered bread, and gave Miss Gershwin pieces of chicken and jars of soup to take home.

Mrs. Dubovsky came up with her solution to Miss Gershwin's dilemma "What she needs, Mrs. Siegel, is a pleasant man to make her happy. When a woman is happy, she gets nice and fat." Mr. Dubovsky obviously made his entire family very happy.

With all her faults, Miss Gershwin kindled the spark of my love of beautiful music. When I occasionally play, "To a Wild Rose," I can almost smell the surprisingly sweet fragrance of the bubbly duck that floated in the bathtub.

When Push Comes to Shove

Cindy and Al were usually the first couple to arrive at my Lamaze class, and the last to leave. As first time parents, they were fascinated with the coming event and had hours of questions. "Is it going to be terribly painful? My Aunt Martha said she almost died! What are the chances that our baby will be normal? Will my coach faint? What is an afterbirth? Does that hurt coming out? Will I need a Caesarean section? My grandmother is a twin!"

Prepared childbirth was just catching on in 1970, and most hospitals and doctors in Los Angeles did not yet honor the trained labor coach's completion certificate, nor did they welcome him (or her) into the delivery room. It was difficult to find obstetricians who were open-minded enough to encourage and enjoy the shared experience. Cindy and Al had found Dr. Goodman, who lived up to his name and would cooperate fully. In fact, he visited my classes to better understand the procedure. Cindy and Al were not married.

As the weeks went by, the nervous coaches became more confident. They began to realize the important role they were about to fill. Women in labor were too involved in their work to think clearly. They responded to firm guidance, gentle affection, and frequent back massages. A good coach could feel tension in his partner, and would remind her to loosen up and float over the contractions with concentrated breathing techniques. Daily practice formed the habits that would be called upon on the big day.

Two weeks after Cindy and Al completed the Lamaze training, they called me. "She's leaking," Al said, "and the contractions are five minutes apart, and strong." I directed them to call Dr. Goodman and to get ready for their practiced trip to Memorial Hospital. Their suitcase had been packed for two months. The contents included two

pretty pajama tops for visitors, a stop watch to time the contractions, pencil and notepad, a photo of a peaceful scene to act as a focal point, lip conditioner, powder or massage lotion, two tennis balls for the coach to use on the lower back, a deck of cards, and baby clothes.

"Estelle, would you do us a big favor?" Al asked. "Would you meet us at the hospital and stay for awhile, for moral support, OK?"

"OK," I replied. "Drive carefully. I'll see you soon." I had been part of several home deliveries, as well as hospital births, and loved the miracle of it all. Watching the doctors become exhilarated co-partners with the parents, sharing the shouts and the tears of a tough job, well done, was always especially rewarding.

In the hospital labor room, my students were working harmoniously together, and were oblivious of my entrance. "Take a deep cleansing breath Cindy. You're doing great sweetheart, the baby will be here before you know it." Nice coaching Al, I thought as I placed my belongings on a chair. Cindy had made good progress and was coping well with her hard contractions, which were now two minutes apart.

This was no time for chatter. She took every moment she could to relax and almost sleep in between the waves of exhausting labor. Al moistened her dry lips with ice chips, and applied cold, wet cloths to her forehead. He was able to tell Cindy when the next contraction was starting and he insisted that she open her eyes and look at the focal point as the abdominal muscles did their work. Good kids; I was so proud of them.

Dr. Goodman arrived and checked her dilatation. Eight centimeters already! She was ready to push. The most difficult part was behind Cindy, but hard work was still ahead. Al supported her

back with pillows as Cindy gulped down a chest full of air, closed her mouth, and bore down. Al counted slowly when the door of the labor room swung open.

In barged the hospital administrator. "I see that you two have different last names," he sneered. "Are you married?"

With disbelief and rage, Dr. Goodman retorted, "Hey, they're about to have a baby. They need to get into the delivery room *now!*"

"Not in my hospital," shouted the administrator.

"You can't mean this," I said incredulously. "We're dealing with lives here."

"Not in my hospital!" insisted the administrator.

"You bastard!" I yelled.

"Let's get the hell out of this place," said Dr. Goodman. "Estelle, get us an ambulance quick!" And to the administrator, "Don't expect to see me or my patients here again."

"Don't push Cindy. *Pant, pant, pant,*" cried Al. Cindy panted frantically until the ambulance arrived. After the longest ten minutes of Cindy's young life, we all reached nearby Washington Hospital. Three minutes later, her ecstatic and much relieved mother pushed out a big, beautiful baby girl. The little one shot out like a missile, and we all shouted as the slippery babe greeted the world with a lusty cry. Minutes later, Al popped open the champagne bottle and we all made a toast to life, love and compassion.

We broke open another bottle of apple juice the following month, in class. Cindy, Al and Felicia visited my new students and shared their story. They brought the article from the Los Angeles Times that announced the termination of the administrator of Memorial Hospital.

The newspaper was dated, September 5: Labor Day.

He was the class "bad boy" and I was crazy about him. Marvie always wore a porky-pie hat, and although he looked very cute in it, he really wore it to make him look taller. Every time we passed each other in the school hall, my face would get so hot and my heart beat like a drum. Somehow, I knew that he felt the same way. I was eleven and he was twelve and a half. Anyone who claims that puppy love is sweet and silly doesn't know what they're talking about. My feelings for him were unbelievably intense.

One day, Marvie gave me a lollipop, offered to carry my books and walk me home. My house was less than two blocks from the school, so we walked very slowly. I remember lowering my shoulders so that I would minimize the height difference (about an inch) and feeling extremely light hearted. As he left, he instructed me to wait five minutes and then look under the concrete flowerpot on my porch. The pot had bulldog shaped short legs with a tiny space under it. I saw a folded paper under it and scraped my hand trying to extract it. But I didn't care if I bled a little ...it was my first love letter!

Of course, I responded with polite affection and a good spray of my sister's best perfume. Under the flowerpot, my response rested until it was mysteriously removed, in the middle of the night?? The notes became an exciting ritual, as did the lollipops. The candy on a stick saved my life because my mouth got so dry when I breathed the same air as my love.

We had a "crowd" that hung out together mostly on each others' porch or stoop. It was all innocent fun and eventually we began to have parties in someone's basement. We jitterbugged to the wonderful music of the big bands, and had lots of fun. Then someone brought in a glass milk bottle. I guessed what would happen next, and I was

right. My first kiss was being preserved for Marvie, however, the bottle pointed to me and Tabby Goldberg. The lights went out and I offered my blushing cheek to Tabby. To my astonishment, Grabby Tabby put his finger under my chin and firmly turned my face up to his and planted a juicy kiss on my mouth. I was very impressed, yet disappointed that this special gift was not shared with my one and only. When Marvie realized what had happened, (I was in a stupor), he began to sulk.

On the way home, we held each other's bruised hands as we were still exchanging love letters. We vowed not to kiss anyone else, and he promised that we wouldn't overdo it. To take better control of this matter, I declared that we would only kiss on holidays. He agreed, but the list of holidays that he came up with was astounding. Not only was there Groundhog Day but Be Kind to Mothers-in-Law Day. His creativity had no end.

A new world opened up to me in high school. Long study hours, piano lessons, the cheering squad etc. took their toll on our romance.

After I moved to California, he joined the Army and we corresponded. A wonderful new young man entered my life and heart, and I married Sam. We fortunately had a long, happy and fulfilled marriage.

Two years after Sam died, I impulsively wrote Marvie a letter.

My business group in New York, received annual training visits from me. I asked him if he and his wife (I had no idea of his marital status) would like to join me for lunch during my next visit. He accepted, and I found myself fantasizing about old times.

When he called for me at my business associate's house, this good-looking guy, who was finally way taller than I, greeted me with a big

hug. We approached his brand new Jaguar and sped off to a local restaurant. His wife had to work and could not be present, he said.

Marvie's smile was still charming, but our values were miles apart. The years had put us on different roads and our goals were not the same. He was a high roller in the casinos and boasted of his big winnings (and his wife *had* to work?) He didn't particularly enjoy reading books, but, oh, those showgirls in Las Vegas!!

Well, it was an interesting experience and gave me final conclusion to my childhood romance. I sometimes wonder if other Brooklyn youngsters are getting wonderfully scraped hands because of that pot on the porch of 9407 Avenue A.

If You've Got It, Don't Lose It

Before you decide not to lose it, you need to know what it is. There was Clara Bow, the "It" girl. She was pretty, had charisma and charm. What about the Marlboro Man and the Old Spice Guy on TV commercials? People would agree that they have it.

The old song, "She Had to Go and Lose It at the Astor" might not have anything to do with it. On the other hand, it could. Just today, I noticed a flyer in the Fitness Center. The heading was, "Lose it at the Fitness Center." If Sun City Residents haven't lost it yet, they really have a problem.

There was an article in today's paper, in the Chicken Soup column, where this middle-aged woman was called, "Baby" by a truck driver who was passing by. It made her wonder and ponder for the rest of the day, if she still had it. Evidently, the truck driver thought so, and it secretly gave her titillating pleasure. That night, when her husband greeted her with, "Hey baby," she embraced him with gratitude and appreciation.

Does everyone have some kind of It? I believe that most people have the capacity to demonstrate it, but not everyone finds it important or relevant enough. If being charismatic, magnetic, interesting and fun is a strain, you ain't got it! Maybe there's a "spark" gene that you inherit, or develop while you're growing up. Also, it takes one to know one because chemistry comes into play. Let's do a little supposing:

He: "Nice to meet you. What's your horoscope sign?"

Conclusion: Boooring. He doesn't have it.

She: "You're the one I've heard about. Why should I be glad to meet you?"

Conclusion: There's a good possibility that she has it. Either that, or she's very conceited.

He: "Hi, I've been watching you all night."

Conclusion: A strong maybe.

She: "Me too. What's your sign?"

Conclusion: She just blew it.

"It" should make you and the people around you happy and excited. Flashing a light of humor and curiosity, the mood is contagious and inspiring. The fortunate person who possesses this trait is intrigued with others and what makes them tick. The recipient is made to feel better about himself and suddenly feels more worthy and intelligent.

Analyzing my family history, I know without hesitation that my mother had it. She drew people to her like moths to a light. Mama Bella was open minded, clever, fun to be with, and thoroughly enjoyed people. Relatives came to her for advice and she made them own up to their actions. One of her faults was also a blessing…she embroidered the truth and made it even truthier. She could get into the mind of a child, and still trickier, into the motives of a teenager. Mama was very special.

The surprise factor was my father, Jack. In his generation, husbands worked from morning until night to support the family, and give them a few extras, like summers in the cooler Catskill Mountains. It was unheard of for men to talk to the kids about schoolwork or their ambitions. To help out with housework was unmentionable. His main way of disciplining us was to shpritz seltzer on us for not assisting our mother with the dishes. This was usually done while my sister and I were sprawled on the floor reading the Sunday comics, which were then called the "jokes."

Yet, in quiet moments, he would single me out and ask how I was doing in school and if I had any problems. There is an incident that I will never erase from my mind. It was in my twelfth year, when I was in the eighth grade. Elections for class officers were being planned and heretofore only boys were elected as presidents. That position was something I really coveted. I expressed my concerns to my father, who took my hand in his and looked me in the eyes with his ocean-blue ones.

"If it can be done, you can do it. Figure out a way to make your friends happy to help you." He had built a successful business from scratch during the depression and I never forgot his valuable advice.

I began collecting Sunday "jokes" from the neighbors, and cut out popular characters. Do you remember, L'il Abner, The Katzenjammer Kids, Flash Gordon, Dick Tracy, and The Dragon Lady? I glued these celebrities on cards, wrote "Vote for Estelle for Pres." with a straight pin on top. So many were glad to wear my campaign cards as it made them laugh and talk it up to others.

In my graduation class picture, I'm smack dab in the center as president of my class. My father was right, and his precious quote was repeated many times to my children. Hopefully, they'll remember that their grandfather had it.

Whatever your definition of this characteristic might be, if you think you've got it, don't lose it…choose it…use it!

All of my father's sisters were eccentric, but Bertha was the strangest. I could never converse with her in an open, comfortable manner, but I loved to hear the family gossip about her latest escapades, and the predictions she made. Aunt Bertha (she was sometimes called Bert behind her back) was scary entertainment that, as a teenager, I admittedly looked forward to. The latest word was that she was coming to cousin Hannah's wedding, all the way from Phoenix, Arizona. I could hardly wait.

Brooklyn, New York, 1940

As family and friends of the wedding party approached the reception room, they scanned the crowd to see if bizarre Aunt Bertha had arrived yet. Something exciting always happened when Bertha was around. Usually, it was an argument or a fight. Necks strained for a possible view of her as the anticipating group reached the narrow door.

East Flatbush Hall was steamy from overheated bodies filled with the sweet wine of celebration. A family wedding was time to stuff yourself with fattening goodies, then dance away a few calories in a frantic hora. Kids were left on their own to explore and reacquaint themselves with cousins they hadn't seen since the last wedding or bar mitzvah. My aunts and uncles determined the success of the affair by the amount of food on the buffet table. This particular occasion would get high marks. It would be praised to the heavens because reaching in that direction was a mountain of chopped liver, in the shape of a monster heart. The sumptuous table was overloaded with bagels, lox, cream cheese, gefiltah fish, herring with onions, a five foot long twisted egg bread, glistening

with poppy seeds, sauerkraut, kosher dill pickles, borscht with sour cream, potato pancakes with apple sauce, blintzes with more sour cream, cream soda, seltzer, Manischewitz wine, and some dainty after dinner mints, for show. This was a wedding!!

Uncle Heshie and Aunt Rivka really went overboard with this shindig, because Hannah, the bride, the eldest daughter, was almost thirty, and had a mustache.

People swarmed around the table, spearing the liver heart and attacking the borscht. Little Doodie, the troublemaker, stuck a huge pickle smack in the middle of the chopped liver, pointing out the phallic symbol to his chuckling cousins. "That's obscene," scolded Aunt Yetta, grabbing the pickle and biting off the top two inches. "Too spicy," she said, replacing the remaining portion back to its liver home, much to the delight of Doodie and his cronies. Dentures were stained pink from beet juice, and vampire-like trickles traveled down shiny chins. Many of my relatives had experienced hunger in the old country, and it was a sin to wastes food. Chubby children were much admired and envied by parents with skinny kids.

Pungent aromas danced everywhere to the loud ethnic music. Above it all, "Mazeltov!": It should only happen to your daughter already. How old is she? "So how much do you think the groom makes?" "How are your piles Boobeleh?" "My doctor is a living wonder. He charges more than anybody." "Your dress is gawjus. Look how it still fits you after so many years."



But where was Aunt Bertha? Would she really travel back to Brooklyn from so far away in Arizona where the cowboys are? Bertha was different from the other aunts because she read lots of

books and never hesitated to speak her mind *loud*, no matter what. What a showoff! Not only that, but some of the family said she was a psychic, only they called it "mashoogenah in the head." Uncle Marty said that she was influenced by a group of gypsies when she was growing up in Romania.

"Look, look, there she is!", nudged several relatives. Bertha's strong stride took her several feet ahead of her little spouse, Uncle Irving. What he lacked in stature, he made up in fortitude and commitment. Bertha's large frame and erect posture commanded attention. Her dark eyes darted from face to face, daring someone to make the first move. Taller than most of the group, she stood like the formidable school principal forced to visit a class of delinquents. Her former beauty had faded into a granite-like facial expression, chiseled by disappointments and bitterness. Her thick, black hair was drawn flat back in a no-nonsense bun. The brown dress of sensible coarse wool was more befitting a union meeting than a festive wedding.

"Hello Aunt Bertha," ventured brave Sarah. "I've had a baby since I saw you three years ago. See, here's her picture." Bertha adjusted her glasses and studied the photograph of the smiling toddler. Pointing to the snapshot, she prophesised, "This child will be evil." Poor Sarah's eyes filled with tears as she ran. "What a thing to say, Aunt Bertha," I said. "Sarah is such a good girl." "The truth must be heard," insisted Bertha as she looked for her next victim.

Uncle Hymie's bottom was inches away from the floor as he kicked out his legs, one at a time, in a lively kazotsky. His sweaty face was stroke red as he crossed his arms across his chest and performed the difficult Russian dance. A ring of panting people danced around him, clapping to the accelerating beat of the music. "That stupid man

is begging for a heart attack," cried out Bertha in her piercing voice. "Ah shaddap Bertie," snapped Uncle Stanley, "Leave the shmuck have some fun. This is a wedding for cryin out loud." "Well, you don't need to use profanities," lectured Bertha. "If you used your brains instead of your mouth, you wouldn't have to…" "Aw, come off it Bertie, You sit on the pot too." "My name is Bertha," she growled, and pivoted around on her sensible oxford shoes. We had to give her credit for dressing up though. Her brown shoelaces were rayon.

"OK boys and girls," shouted the bandleader, who was also the social director and photographer. "Let's all sit down for the grand event, the wedding cake!" Drums rolled and a trumpet heralded in the long awaited highlight of the wedding. In moved a large cart with a cake seven stories high. The pied piper of instant fat was followed by assorted squealing children, decked out with large, white napkins, acting as bibs to protect the on-sale clothes from Klein's.

Rumor had it the cake cost $27.50 from Kaplan's bakery. So who cared if the doll bride on the tipsy top of the cake was prettier than the real one?

As chunks were cut and plopped on plates, I watched as Bertha sat quietly with her strong, ringless fingers folded tightly together. Clasping, then unclasping them impatiently, she began to rearrange the crumbs on the pink tablecloth. Sitting alone, she smashed the crumbs with her fingernails. In spite of the cloud of gloom that clung to Bertha's aura, people all around her animatedly exchanged family stories and the latest jokes from the Fred Allan radio show.

The merry shouts and hoopla of the crowd were a close match to the magnified volume of the band. No one paid attention to the little kids, who were having their own private party. They played

hide and seek under the tables, peeking under dresses whenever the opportunity presented itself. Biffie was sliding into second base, which was under table #9. It was a good time to rest, but then he spotted a pair of silky shoelaces. Like a true free spirit, he carefully knotted them all together into slip knots. He was a good boy scout and practiced this particular feat many times, on other dupes. Slowly, Biffie slithered away and joined the other kids, whispering in their ears of his daring achievement. I did nothing to stop the inevitable.

From the megaphone, came the announcement, "OK boys and girls, bring your chairs closer so we can all see the beautiful presents the bride and groom received from all of their generous loved ones."

Chairs screeched across the wood floor as everyone scurried to get a better view. As Bertha proceeded to rise and take a marching step to the side, she tripped over her rayon laces and clumsily cartwheeled herself into a bottoms up position on the floor. A few hurrying relatives tripped over her, sprawling to the floor. After the initial surprise, they began to giggle and shriek like children in silly play. All but Bertha were having fun. She scowled in mortification, as the concerned bride and others came to her aid. "Get away from me you hoodlums," she shouted. "I curse all of you!" And pointing to the center of the satin white figure, she broadcast to all, "I especially curse that unborn baby in your womb!" The bride, flushed with embarrassment, almost fell as she fled the nightmare.

It was good to get back to my cozy home after that traumatic episode. Mama turned the radiator on and as it pinged and clinked its sing-song clamor, she gave us all glasses of hot tea and honey. As I wrapped my chilled hands around the glass, I asked my father, "Why is Bertha so mean? Do you remember her childhood Pa?"

"I'm sorry to see her like this." He answered. "None of us had an easy life, but she took it differently. The rest of us made jokes about the hard times, but she didn't laugh too much. Maybe it started when we were small…"

He lit his Camel cigarette and filled in the pieces I was curious to learn about.

Brownsville, the Brooklyn Ghetto, 1927

Bertha was the fourth of nine children born to Gussie and Sam Siegel. Some of the memories of Rumania, her homeland, would always be sharp, even though she was only ten years old when the family migrated to the "streets of paved gold". She remembered the fertile flatlands of Walachia, her birthplace. Her family moved from place to place a great deal, buying and trading household trinkets, which they polished and sold for a small profit. Many times, the buyers would offer food instead of money, and this was gratefully accepted.

One day, little Bertha and her brother Jacob, (my father), were playing on a grassy hill which bordered a neighbor's farm. They were thirsty, and too tired to walk to the Danube River for a drink.

"Look at that lazy cow grazing in the meadow," said Jacob. "I'll try to get some milk from it." "You've never done it before," said Bertha. "Be careful."

Jacob approached the animal and proceeded to milk the cow. Bertha watched her brother sail ten feet into the air as the furious bull kicked him on the side of the head. The scar was a reminder for the rest of Jacob's life. Bertha decided on the spot to be suspicious of all animals. That "cow" seemed so friendly but look what happened when Jacob got up close to it. Later, Bertha transferred this mistrust to people.

When the Siegel clan settled in Brownsville, a part of Brooklyn, New York, it was impossible to see whether or not the streets were made of gold. The famous streets were literally covered with humanity. People crowded to this area because the rent was the cheapest. Many nationalities, religions and cultures made up a colorful patchwork quilt of immigrants. Shouts in every language were thrust from one tenement to another, across the street, and even face to face, if one wished to be heard. Real gypsies in satin skirts and white teeth rubbed elbows with Hasidic Jews in long black coats. The colors of skin were like a rainbow, and though there was a special pride in one's background and culture, there were few racial slurs. Children from all backgrounds urinated in the gutters. Everyone was struggling to become Americanized and to rise from the mire of poverty.

Bertha was quick to learn, and she read avidly. She decided that she would marry a wealthy man. Her dark beauty attracted many fine would-be suitors, but they were rejected abruptly when she learned of their financial status. Panic began to set in when her two younger sisters married. Her parents pressured her not to be so picky and to marry soon. When Mr. Irving Shafer, a widower in his forties, began to court Bertha, she minimized his bald head, his short stature and the big cigar in-between his brown teeth. That only made him look like the rich man he claimed to be.

Gussie and Sam opened up a small shop in front of their apartment, on top of the hill, near Harlem. The store was filled with shelves of ceramic figurines and assorted knickknacks. People loved to have these pieces of "art" to dress up their shabby homes. The glass ladies in their long gowns and bejeweled tresses become bits of romantic

fantasies that lifted the hearts of housewives whose bucket of dreams had long since spilled into the gutter. Bertha observed the faces of the customers as they allowed the sunlight to reflect momentary illusions of romance from the highly polished dolls. She felt their need, and planned to answer their desire through her merchandise. By the time they had left the shop, they had an armful of trinkets and had spent twice as much as they had intended. Although the money went to her parents, Bertha felt power and was in her first stage of self training.

At the foot of the hill, there was a trolley track. Jacob, at age sixteen, was fortunate enough to get a job as a conductor. When he started, he was paid twelve cents a day. After two years, he was making thirty seven cents a day, while thousands were unemployed. "Put your penny in a slot; a trolley ride you'll like a lot!" sang Jacob to his riders.

One snowy day, Bertha watched her younger sibling playing with their sled in the snow. The hill, of course, was a major attraction, Isaac, Bertha's little brother with the club foot, loved to slide down the hill on his sled. For a short time, he was able to forget his handicap.

As Isaac readied himself on the top of the hill, Bertha visualized a scene in slow motion. She saw the trolley coming to the intersection at the base of the hill, but she said nothing. She had to find out if these occasional flashes of premonitions were really true. An erotic flush filled her hips and chest. Her heart began to beat faster. Coolly, she watched little Isaac cry out with glee as he hopped on the sled and began his dash downhill. The trolley arrived at the intersection at the same split second that Isaac did. Clang, clang, clang jangled the bell. Swoosh went the car and covered Isaac and his sled. A few neighbors who had seen the whole incident, held their mouths as they ran to the

accident. When they arrived, they saw Isaac with a whiter than snow complexion, shaking like troubled jello. Bertha waited as they carried her hysterical brother up the hill. Gussie and Sam were horrified at the near tragedy. "Bertha," admonished her parents, "Why didn't you watch your little brother?" "But I did watch him," she insisted. "I swear I didn't take my eyes off him!"

Years passed and Bertha and Irving had three sons. Only the youngest, Walter, amounted to anything. He became a lawyer. His two brothers could have been his constant clients as they were always in some sort of trouble. Their gang activities and shadowy deals were always a painful source of embarrassment and disappointment for Bertha. She insisted that she and her boys were far above the lowly upbringing of her unlucky nieces and nephews. But, to avoid future reckoning with the relatives, she decided that it would be prudent to remove herself as far as possible. Luckily, she developed asthma. Irving also wheezed but never cut down on his huge cigars. Bertha's doctor advised a drier climate, and who would challenge a doctor's advice after paying such a big fee?

I was sorry to lose track of my peculiar aunt as I couldn't bring myself to start a correspondence with her. Happily, I ran into my Aunt Molka, who taught school in the Bronx. We were both shopping for the dresses we would wear at the wedding, when we bumped into each other right in front of Neddick's in downtown Brooklyn. Molka was talkative and full of humorous stories, and it was always fun to exchange ideas with her.

"Aunt Molka, you look terrific!" I said truthfully. "Where did you get that tan?" "You'll never guess," she giggled. "I just got back from Phoenix. Your Uncle David had to go on business, and as long

as it was between semesters, I went too. *Aaand*, guess who I saw?" "You saw Aunt Bertha?" I gasped. "Please tell me everything."

We took a booth inside the deli, ordered our hot dogs and orange Julius, and for the next hour, dear Aunt Molka brought me up to date on the saga of weird Aunt Bertha.

Phoenix, Arizona, 1937

The sky was incredibly blue, and was *sooo* hot! But dry, yes. It certainly was dry. Enough to dehydrate the least bit of congestion in asthmatic lungs. Bertha, Irving and the two older sons, had found a modest apartment to rent. Uncle Irving wasn't half as rich as he had made out to be. They also rented a small store on Main Street for their future business. Gussie and Sam had given them several boxes willed with chatchckalas. Bertha displayed them in the window and made sure that the sun's rays would catch the gold glint of the figurines. "Start those fantasies spinning," she ordered the dolls. Many of the residents in Phoenix were retired, or vacationing, with time on their hands. Wouldn't books be a smart idea?

Bertha read the newspapers carefully. The obituary columns particularly held her interest. She always followed up on the elderly who departed, by calling on their families as a sympathetic neighbor. And by the way, did they have any old books or white elephants they would like to clear out? That was the start of her antique/book store. She picked up treasures for next to nothing, dusted them prudently, and repaired the crackly book covers. The shiny statuettes sparkled in the window as planned. Bertha gave her new shoppers time and space to explore the clever little animals captured in glass, waiting for a friendly home to decorate. The customers always paused at the

bouquet of old silk flowers, still blushing with beauty, nestled in an array of emerald green satin leaves. The vase was milky white, which surprised the viewer with an iridescent glow. Discreetly tucked away nearby was an apothecary jar filled with tiny, round wooden logs that had been soaked in rose oil. The effect was nostalgic and captivating.

Sturdy wooden shelves supported books of every size and color. Each radiated its own musty scent. It was impossible not to bring each volume to one's nose as the fragrance told its own story. One could detect rich leather, chocolatey pipe tobacco, ozone and citrus. Oriental and Turkish rugs adorned the walls, softening voices. A proud Greek soldier doll, with its fluffy skirt and pom pom boots, majestically guarded the Rudolph Valentino bedroom lamp, with its hanging strands of glowing beads. A music box in the shape of a graceful blue harp, played "When Your Hair Has Turned to Silver", as the shopper approached.

Giving her people plenty of time to browse, Bertha glimpsed at them from time to time, estimating what would really excite them. One of her clients wore a gold violin pin on her blouse. "Madame", said Bertha, "Have you seen this collection of biographies of the European musical masters?" Bertha saw the quick movement of her patron's eyebrow, the parted lips, and eyes searching for the prize. Right again, thought Bertha as she slowly handed one of the old volumes to the impatient woman. Bertha read faces, and watched body movements. She could smell success.

Uncle Irving only wanted to smell cigars, and Bertha was hungry for intellectual stimulation. If only Walter hadn't decided to remain in New York, she would have had someone to talk to. Her other sons were still good for nothings and were constantly picked up by the

police for speeding on their motorcycles, or for disturbing the peace. The only one who inherited her brains was far away.

Bertha's need to direct people was a constant hunger. One of the books she acquired for her shop was on palm reading. She was fascinated by the prospect of holding sessions with people, although she did not look forward to touching their hands. The information was mastered in a short time. Bertha also decided to incorporate a skill that an old Greek woman, called Ya Ya had taught her in Brownsville. Ya Ya would boil some finely ground Turkish coffee in a "briki", which was a small brass pot with a long handle. The fragrant kafes needed to boil and foam to the brim of the pot three times. It was then poured into dainty demitasse cups and sipped slowly witout disturbing the thick grounds at the bottom of the cup. When the mixture was too thick to drink, a little saucer was placed on the top of the cup, which was quickly reversed allowing the grounds to flow to the saucer, forming unusual patterns in the cup. It took imaginative talent to interpret the design.

Business cards were printed explaining Bertha's new service:

EUROPEAN PSYCHIC

Palm & Psychic Readings
Reader & Advisor
On all problems of Life, Love,
Business, Marriage, Money & Health

She can and will help you
solve your problems.

ALL READINGS ARE PRIVATE & CONFIDENTIAL.
FOR APPOINTMENT, CALL DICKENS 2-3947

These cards were placed into each book she sold. Before long, people called for appointments, which were made outside of store hours to ensure quiet privacy. In back of the shop, she placed a small antique table between two comfortable cushioned antique chairs. A little soft pillow was placed in the center of the table. The client, who was always a woman, would place her hand on the gentle mound, and Bertha would light the Tiffany lamp above. The briki was ready to heat up on the electric burner. Bertha's probing dark eyes and sensitive intuition enlightened her before a word was spoken. Nothing was missed. The client's nails, texture of skin and body scent were all accounted for. Did the woman's finger tremble?

Bertha began by charging $5 a sitting. Within two years, her fee was $50. People gratefully put their names on a long waiting list. The antique book dealer became a human magnet, who drew to her cold heart, lonely, fearful and unfulfilled people, who were as desperate as Bertha was for human conversation.

She become very effective in her work. The sitting space in the back of the store, became a cozy enclave, with drapes and cushions to lean on. Various colored lights were used to add to the secluded atmosphere. Bertha knew how to woo and keep her people.

As her reputation grew, so did her sense of pride and strength. She was delighted to receive the wedding invitation. Now she would show those worthless excuses for relatives, what it means to be in control of one's life, and of others.

Aunt Molka had shed much light on the puzzle I was trying to piece together. But there was a segment that needed filling in. My imagination would have to be the tool to complete the missing part

that occurred prior to Aunt Bertha's second return. What were Bertha's thoughts; what made her come back?

A year had passed since that suffocating wedding. All those uncouth people, crawling around her, still made her shiver with discomfort. She remembered the humiliation of her stupid fall, and how they laughed at her. But, she ended up the winner after all. The look of horror and fear in their faces when she uttered the curse was a delicious treat to nibble on.

"Good morning Mrs. Shafer," said the mailman cheerfully. "It looks like you've got a letter from someone in New York." Bertha pulled the letter from the mailman's possessive hands, and glared into his eye until he left. The letter was a notice of the funeral for Heshie and Rivka's grandchild. This would become the final touch on last year's episode. It was too bad that the baby had to die, but it was doomed from conception, perhaps even before. And it wasn't that she looked forward to attending funerals. After all, she wasn't a witch. She merely wished to conclude this incident and put it away neatly, like a book, in its rightful place, on the shelf.

"Irving," said Bertha to her husband, "I'm closing the shop for five days. I have some business on the east coast."

Brooklyn, New York, 1941

Autumn was kind to Brooklyn. The winds swept the borough cleaner than it had been for months. People sniffed the air to cleanse the soot from their lungs. They smelled the change of seasons. Snow was on its way.

Brooklyn is famous for its cemeteries. They have a unique skyline all their own. Crowded together, side by side, stones of various heights

and thicknesses, fight for space. Stars of David are everywhere, marking the final resting place of the pious and not-so-pious. The monuments stretch out for acres, each one crammed with secrets and untold stories. A tiny plot was waiting this day to be filled.

Across the street from the cemetery, was an old, weather-beaten chapel. Sobs and occasional shrieks could be heard from the building throughout the neighborhood. The attending children looked frightened to see and hear the raw emotion surrounding them. They were unusually quiet. They were warned that if they played tricks, or misbehaved in any way, their arms and legs would be broken immediately.

The philosophy of the group was that in spite of tragedy, life does continue, and so the traditional table laden with juice and small cakes was available to nourish their lives with.

As the rabbi entered, voices were hushed and the family and visitors took their seats. It is so difficult to try to understand why a young baby, so innocent, so loved, should be called by the Almighty, in her sleep, in her little crib. She had not been sick, and the new parents were so happy with little Lana," sympathized the bearded cleric. Stifled moans from the childless bride of one year, caused ripples of choking wails of despair. The eulogy continued. "Perhaps the Holy One called little Lana to a better place. His wisdom cannot be questioned." Amidst sobs and comforting embraces, the tribute to Lana continued.

"Will you look at that," whispered Aunt Lil to her daughter, Ruthie. "We're all crying our hearts out and, just take a look!" She pointed her eyes towards Bertha, who sat across the aisle. "Get a load of Miss Fency Shmency from Delancey Street." While practically everyone had a handkerchief to their eyes or nose, Bertha sat royally

with a near smirk on her calm face. "Mama, the feet, look at the feet!" gasped Ruthie. They both stared at the sensible oxfords tap, tap, tapping to a silent tune. "My God," cried Lil unbelievingly, "The son of a bitch is dancing at the funeral!"

After the rabbi finished what he hoped would be meaningful and soothing to the bereaved group, everyone slowly moved to the exit, pausing for some refreshments to bolster their strength for the next phase, the burial.

The little pink casket, piled high with blossoms, was slowly lowered into its crevice. The immediate family took turns shoveling earth into the cavity. This made a terrible thud on the casket. The childless mother screamed and had to be restrained as she struggled to join her dead baby. Small children hugged the legs of their parents and looked up for reassurance.

Bertha was the first to leave the crowd. She silently walked towards the far end of the cemetery, which was close to the entrance of the subway. Soon, she would be at La Guardia airport, and back to clear, dry air, and to people who pay to listen to her wisdom. The leaves scrunched pleasantly under her oxfords, and she should have been feeling satisfied, but there was that old feeling again. It was a sense of foreboding that she could not shake off.

At the edge of the cemetery, was the stonecutter's workshop. As a young girl, Bertha spent hours watching Mr. O'Donnell chisel out the designs on the tombstones. He then artfully engraved names and dates into the monument. She wondered if Mr. O'Donnell was still there. Who would engrave his stone? She pondered over this as she approached the masonry.

"Not even a goodbye on such an occasion," remarked Uncle Shulam. Several kinsmen watched Bertha as she departed. They

saw her stop suddenly as she clutched her middle and sank to her knees, screeching, "Oh no-o-oh!" Bertha slumped forward and once again was bottoms up. This time, however, she was out like a candle. The family hastened to her, but were afraid to come too close lest whatever befell her was contagious.

Away from the burial site, the youngsters lightened up, clasped hands, and hopping around their strange aunt sang, "Ring around a Bertha."

Nobody noticed that old Mr. O'Donnell had left early that day. He had come down with the flu and left the stone he was working on unfinished. Around the edge of the gravestone were engraved beautiful flowers and a graceful bird in flight. In the center, the letters read, REST IN PEACE, DEAR BERT. If he got well in time, O'Donnell would make the deadline for Bertram Hockfinkle's unveiling.